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Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/41522451.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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# A Camp Christmas

by TheSofterGentlerMe

Summary

Adora has managed to finish her first semester at college and now she's going home with Glimmer for Christmas. Glimmer has already told her that her family does Christmas a bit differently but Adora is also having issues with this being the first Christmas being estranged from her mother. How will things play out for her?

# Chapter 1

Chapter Summary

> Adora gets ready to move out of the dorms for the winter break and is planning on going back to Glimmer's home at Camp Bright Moon for Christmas.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Are you sure your parents are alright with Catra and I staying over Christmas break at your place?" Adora said as she packed the last of her stuff into a box, sealed it with tape, and carefully labeled the box with what was inside.

"Adora, really, I get it, you're anxious but you gotta stop asking me that," Glimmer said as she crammed another load of clothes into a garbage bag before tying it off and tossing it on top of another set of bags. She stood up and walked around the small dorm room to make sure nothing had been left behind, grabbing a pair of sandals out from under the bed and throwing them on top of the garbage bags as she went. "It's not like Catra doesn't stay there when she's in the area."

Adora involuntarily smiled at the mention of her girlfriend. It'd been several weeks since she'd seen her as Catra had been traveling around with a farrier, learning the trade, and they didn't get to talk nearly enough, never mind seeing each other in person.

"I know," Adora said, "but Christmas is a family thing and I don't want us to be in the way."

Glimmer went over and put a hand on Adora's shoulder as she said, "Adora, you have been specifically invited to our celebration. Bow is going to be there, you're going to be there, and Catra is going to be there. It's going to be fun and if it isn't, well, you're wrong, yes, it is."

Adora sighed as she sat down on the bare mattress of her dorm bed. She looked around the room that she'd spent the last few months in since she'd left Camp Bright Moon as she thought about her life. In just six months, she'd walked away from a guaranteed college education, her work at the Christian summer camp she'd attended for years, her worldview of herself as a good Christian, and her mother. Against that she had made new friends, finally admitted her love for Catra, and was able to openly be herself but even then she often found herself questioning her decision. When Catra was around, it was easy to forget or at least deal with but Catra had dropped out of school entirely to work for a traveling farrier and so it wasn't often that she was able to forget it.

"I guess so," Adora said, looking at her little pile of boxes. Even the boxes were a reminder of what she'd lost. She'd left her old job at the Camp Horde for the Lord with a single bag. She didn't think of it at the time but that had been all the possessions she'd had in the world. The fact she had more clothes than just what someone would wear to a summer camp was because of the kindness of the people she'd met since. Adora was terrified of relying on those people. Her mother ran an outreach program to the poor and homeless from the church Adora had grown up in and Adora could hear her voice clearly.

“It’s one thing to need a little help every once in a while but those lazy bums just show up week after week with their hands out,” Ms. Weaver had said on more than one occasion. “They’re lucky we show the Lord’s grace to them or they’d have to actually get out and work for once in their lives.”

“You alright?” Glimmer asked as she sat down next to Adora. “You’re not worried about your grades still are you?”

Adora grimaced at that as she shook her mother’s voice out of her head. Her grades had been another source of stress for her and in the stress of packing and the worry about spending the holiday at Glimmer’s home, she’d managed to forget about her grades for a little bit. When she’d started she’d been surprised to find out she needed remedial math. She’d been good at math at the private Christian school she’d attended but it turned out what she’d learned didn’t make the cut for college. At first she’d taken solace in the admissions officer telling her that she wasn’t out of the ordinary, that a lot of incoming students required it, but then she’d started classes and found that she had the same issues with history. She’d immediately spoken with her advisor who’d talked with her a little bit and figured she’d have the same issues with science. Her first eight weeks had been dismal as she’d struggled to keep a schedule and learned how to study properly and take notes. Her grades had shown it and the low scores had been disheartening. There’d been many late night crying sessions about her grades, on top of other crying sessions about all the other stress in her life, but Glimmer had helped her through those.

“No, I calculated everything and in most of my classes, I’ll still get B’s even if I bombed the finals,” Adora said. “I just… I don’t

know."

"Worried about everything else?" Glimmer said with a little nudge of her shoulder to Adora.

"Yeah, everything else," Adora said.

"Want to talk about it?" Glimmer said. Adora just shook her head. "You sure? No Bible verse for this one?"

Adora looked over at Glimmer, a smile on her face, and Adora knew she was teasing her but one did jump to Adora's head.

"Ephesians 6:1," Adora said with a tired voice as she stood up off the bed and walked over to the window. She looked out at the brick wall that was the only view they had in the room and she could hear Glimmer waiting but she didn't want to elaborate. Finally, Glimmer spoke up.

"OK, Adora, you know I don't know that off the top of my head and I'm guessing from the way you're acting it's something critical about yourself."

"How do you know, if you don't know it," Adora said without turning around.

“Because I’ve lived with you for a few months now and I know you’re critical of everything you do,” Glimmer said. “You going to tell me or am I going to have to dig through your stuff to get your Bible?”

Adora heard Glimmer standing up and picking up a box. She turned around as she said, “Please don’t mess up my packing.”

Glimmer gripped a flap on the box and met Adora’s eyes as she said, “Tell me then.”

“That’s not even the right box! I have them labeled!” Adora said.

“I’m in college, Adora. I don’t read anything I don’t have to,” Glimmer said and made a show of flexing her arm like she was about to pull the flap back.

“Fine,” Adora said with a sigh. “Ephesians 6:1 says, ‘Children, obey your parents in the Lord: for this is right.’ Now please put my box down.”

Glimmer set the box down as she said, “Adora, that’s bull. One, you’re not a child. Two, that should go both ways. Your mom is treating you like crap.”

Adora looked away as she said, “She’s just worried about me being a good Christian.”

“She’s worried about how it makes her look,” Glimmer said as she stepped up to Adora and hugged her before stepping back with her hands on Adora’s shoulder. “Adora, look at me.” Adora looked at her and Glimmer went on. “If being a good Christian means freezing out your daughter because she happens to love someone then I hope I’m never a good Christian because I’d rather just be a good person and love my daughter.”

“It’s not that simple,” Adora said, shaking her head.

“Fuck yes, it is,” Glimmer said and saw Adora flinch at the obscenity. “Sorry for the cussing but I’m serious; it’s that simple. You’re her daughter and yeah, parents and kids fight but what she’s doing is unforgivable in my opinion.”

Adora shook her head again and wiped at her eyes as she said, “I can’t explain it easily but it’s really not that simple.”

Glimmer looked at her again before giving her another hug.

“You’re wrong but I’m not fighting you on this one,” Glimmer said. She paused and then grinned at Adora. “Right now at least.”

Adora snorted a little laugh at the look on Glimmer’s face and nodded.

“OK, enough of this,” Glimmer said. “Bow will be here soon. Let’s get our stuff down to the lobby, alright?”

Adora nodded and the two ran out to find a cart to load their stuff on. The carts were in short supply as the whole dorm was moving out that day and there weren’t enough for every room. Adora politely tried to get one a few times with no luck. Then she saw Glimmer walk up to one person who was unloading their stuff outside into a car. Glimmer picked up their final two bags and set them onto the ground next to the car before walking off with the cart while shouting thanks at the person for holding onto the cart for her. The person looked up in surprise and confusion at Glimmer’s words and Adora didn’t see if their expression changed as she buried her face in her hands in embarrassment as Glimmer came in the door.

“Found one!” Glimmer shouted across the lobby at Adora.

“I can not believe you did that,” Adora said as they rode the elevator back up to their room.

“He was almost done with it,” Glimmer said. “No harm.”

“What if he had more stuff!?” Adora said.

“Then he’ll have to move his car first,” Glimmer said. “He can’t leave it unattended there. So either way, he’d have to give up the cart.”

The rest of the process went smoothly as Glimmer and Adora loaded the cart up. Adora's possessions didn't take up much room, especially since they were packed so neatly, which was good because Glimmer's stack of bags of various varieties spilled all over the place and took some effort to get stacked so they could move it.

"They had boxes," Adora said for the third time as they finally got into the elevator.

"Yeah, but this was easier," Glimmer replied as she held one bag to keep it from sliding again. They made their way to the driveway in front of the building and started unloading their stuff next to a concrete planter with a bench built into it. A cold wind swirled around them as someone took the cart from them almost before they had their stuff off of it and then the two sat down on the bench next to their stuff.

"It's not going to rain is it?" Adora said, looking up at the low clouds.

"It's not supposed to," Glimmer said. "Bow should be here any minute though. You know how he is about being on time."

Half an hour later and Glimmer was tapping her foot in irritation and looking at her phone, wondering where in the world Bow had gone off to.

“He hasn’t answered my texts,” Glimmer said in irritation. “And we’re sitting out here freezing.”

“He’s probably driving and can’t answer,” Adora replied. “And it’s not that cold.”

“He better be driving and it’s cold enough,” Glimmer grumbled as she pulled her purple hoodie in closer to herself. Adora began to tap her foot as she hummed to herself and Glimmer looked at her as she tried to place the tune. Adora saw her looking and blushed a little as she stopped and looked away.

“Sorry,” Adora said.

“For what? I was trying to figure out what the song was,” Glimmer said.

“It was nothing,” Adora said.

Glimmer grinned as she said, “Which means it’s religious.”

“It might not have been,” Adora said defensively.

“Adora, really, anytime you try to pretend like something you did was nothing, it revolves around your religion,” Glimmer said. “You don’t have to be embarrassed about it. Well, maybe a bit, like that thing you said earlier about obeying your parents but come on, I watched you quote *multiple* Bible verses after Bow and I dragged you and your girlfriend out of a flooded river. I’m not going to judge you.”

“Fine, it was a Christmas song,” Adora said.

“And you were worried I was going to think that was weird or something?” Glimmer said. “When we’re going home for Christmas?”

“It’s just… I don’t know,” Adora said. “I’m just self-conscious about it. Besides, you had that whole warning speech about how your family does Christmas a little differently the other day and I don’t want to offend anyone.”

“You’ll do fine and, wait, *there! He’s finally here!”* Glimmer shouted as she pointed at Bow driving up towards them in the old minivan his dads got him for college. Glimmer jumped to her feet and stepped in front of the minivan as Bow brought it to a screeching stop. “Where have you been!?”

Bow got out with a smile as Glimmer came around and grabbed him for a kiss.

“First, traffic safety, Glimmer. Second, I had to stop to pick up a surprise for Adora,” Bow said, looking at her. “It took a little longer than I expected.”

“Bow, you didn’t have to get me anything,” Adora said.

“He didn’t,” Catra’s voice sounded from the car as she slid the back door open. “He just picked me up.”

Adora’s whole face lit up with joy as Catra climbed out of the back of the car. In a flash she was on her feet and running to her. Catra grabbed her as the two collided and picked her up in a twirl before setting her down with a kiss.

“How come I don’t get a greeting like that?” Glimmer said with a grin at Bow.

“Because I was too busy trying not to run you over and explain myself for being late,” Bow said as they waited for the two to acknowledge the rest of the world.

“Hey, Adora,” Catra said with a little grin after they finally broke their kiss. “Missed me did you?”

“You have no idea,” Adora said, her forehead resting against Catra’s forehead.

“I think you bruised my nose with that kiss, so yeah, I do,” Catra said.

Adora leaned down and kissed Catra’s nose gently, causing her to blush, before saying, “Better?”

Catra nodded before they finally turned back to Bow and Glimmer.

“Are you done?” Glimmer said with a laugh, her arm around Bow’s waist. “Do we need to throw a blanket in the back for you two?”

Both Adora and Catra blushed hard at that and didn’t respond as Bow said, “Don’t tease. Are we ready to go?”

“I was ready half an hour ago,” Glimmer said with a little bump of her hip against him.

“Then how about we get your immaculately packed stuff into the van?” Bow replied as he stepped up and grabbed one of Glimmer’s trash bags. There was some laughter and chatting as they got everything loaded in the back of the van next to Bow’s things he was bringing home and they were soon on the road. Catra and Adora held hands and snuggled up together on the middle bench seat as Bow drove along.

Chapter End Notes

This isn't going to get updated on any kind of regular schedule, as I'm also working on *Illusions*, but I wanted to go ahead and post this because I had hit a bit of a snag on *Illusions* and I wanted to put this out there. I've been kind of pecking at it for a little while and I thought about doing it as a chapter by chapter entry would be a way to get it slowly out there. Anyway, I hope you enjoyed this chapter and look forward to getting the next one out to you at some point.

# Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

Everyone piles into Bow's van for the drive back to Glimmer's home.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The drive to Camp Bright Moon, where Glimmer's parents lived, was only a couple of hours by car if taking a leisurely route. Which they did, stopping for gas at a gas station that had an attached restaurant with a pirate ship built inside of it and a giant stuffed bear, getting pictures next to both, stopping at Bow's insistence at various roadside markers so he could read them, and just generally chatting with each other as they drove.

As they drove, they passed out of the fields and trees of where their college sat and entered the steep hills and heavily wooded forests that always meant summer camp to Adora. It was a bit different now though. She'd never seen the area in the winter and she kept feeling like she was in a brand new place as she looked at the bare trees.

"You should have seen it in late October with all the leaves changed. Reggie and I went to some horse festival up here, remember?" Catra said as she hugged Adora. "It was amazing."

"I wish I'd come down for Thanksgiving," Adora said.

“I told you that you’d regret staying at school,” Glimmer said from the front seat.

“I had to study,” Adora said as she watched the hills and trees going past. “Besides, I got to see Catra then too.”

“How did you do by the way?” Catra said, squeezing Adora’s hand and ignoring Glimmer shaking her head at Catra from the front seat.

“I did pretty good I think,” Adora said with a big smile.

“You have been freaking out about that all semester! Now you’re all calm!?” Glimmer said, turning around in her seat to glare at Adora.

“Turn around, Glimmer!” Bow said. “That’s not safe!”

Glimmer shot Bow a look but sat down correctly in the seat while still twisted around to look over her shoulder at Adora.

“I told you earlier I know I did alright,” Adora said.

Catra kissed the top of Adora's head from where she was leaning on her shoulder as she said, "I'm glad you're feeling better about it. It sounded like a rough semester for you. You know what the Bible says about perseverance."

Adora sat up with a raised eyebrow as she said, "I do actually and I know how you feel about all of that so now I really want to know what you think it says."

Catra grinned as she said, "Oh, you know, just the usual verse about it."

Adora gave a soft look with wide eyes back at Catra as she said, "Which one? Come on. I want to hear you quote it, sweetheart. It'd mean so much to me."

Catra's grin turned to a soft smile.

"The one that says, 'Study hard for the Lord your God will reward you with snuggles from your girlfriend at the end of the semester.' I believe it was in one of Paul's letters to the Greeks," Catra replied.

Adora snorted as she said, "Yes, I can completely see Paul saying that."

“He was really big into girlfriends snuggling with each other if I remember right,” Catra said.

“You sure that’s just not you?” Bow said, glancing in the rear-view mirror at Catra.

“Just following the Good Word,” Catra said as she leaned over and nuzzled her head at Adora’s shoulder. Adora put an arm around her as Catra gave a little contented sigh.

They passed a few signs about local Amish businesses and then shortly after that they saw the first sign for both Camp Horde for the Lord and for Camp Bright Moon. It pointed down a two lane highway and Adora had always felt like she was truly entering the wild wilderness when she’d come before because the trees crowded in close to the highway, looming over it on the hills. However, the feeling wasn’t as pronounced this time since the late afternoon light was streaming through the leafless trees and making the road seem not so hemmed in. Adora was getting better glimpses of the river both camps sat on as well as it ran along the road. A handful of miles further down, they saw another sign pointing the way to Camp Horde for the Lord, if they’d had any urge to drive past, and shortly afterwards Glimmer began to sing as they saw another sign for Camp Bright Moon.

“Almost home again, just can’t wait to get back home again,” Glimmer sang to the tune of *On The Road Again.* “The bed I love is waiting at the end and I just can’t wait to get back home again.”

Adora found herself eager to get back as well. It wasn't home like she knew but it was a home for her. She thought of waking up with Catra in the morning again like they had all summer and being able to spend as much time as possible with her. Then she thought of spending time around Glimmer's family without the excuse of camp to draw her away and felt a little nervous again.

"We have arrived!" Bow said as he turned into the gates of the camp. The gates had big iron quarter moons cut out of sheet steel on either side with the words Camp Bright Moon going over the road on an iron frame tall enough that a bus could drive under it. Adora smiled as she saw Glimmer perk up even more. The trees around the entrance gave way quickly to the open field that the main part of the camp sat in. Bow turned off the well maintained gravel road onto a dirt road that went along the trees before disappearing into them. It had a little sign that said "Private Drive" at the turn and it led to Glimmer's childhood home.

Bow pulled into the clearing in front of Glimmer's house and pulled up to the telephone pole laid into the ground to indicate parking. Several other cars were already there as Adora looked at the old Victorian house. It had meticulous fretwork around the eaves and the wraparound porch and everything was carefully restored and painted in bright pastel colors. Adora had commented to Glimmer at some point over the semester at school that the place reminded her a bit of a castle and Glimmer had laughed and agreed before telling Adora that she used to pretend to be a princess all the time when she was growing up because she'd thought the same thing.

Catra got out and stretched before suddenly shivering as the breeze blew past them. She flipped up the hood on her hoodie

and seconds later both Bow and Adora started making little adoring noises.

"Yes, it's got cat ears molded into the hood," Catra said with a roll of her eyes and a smile.

"Sheesh, you'd think they'd never seen a hoodie before," Glimmer said.

"You all made it!" a voice called from the house and they all turned to see Glimmer's father walking out and waving at them. Glimmer ran over to her dad to hug him as her mother came out behind him. The others followed along as they greeted each other, Adora and Catra hanging back a little before getting pulled into the little crowd for hugs as well.

Micah had his arm around Bow's shoulders as he said, "Are you sure your dads don't mind you being here for Christmas?"

"They're fine," Bow said. "They'll be at one of my brother's houses for Christmas."

"Dad, I told you he said it was fine," Glimmer replied.

"But I wanted to ask him myself," Micah replied.

“How about we get inside and out of the cold,” Angella said as she opened the door. “You’ve had a long drive after all.”

“It’s not that long, Mom,” Glimmer said with a smile but went inside anyway.

The group went inside, Catra and Adora sticking by each other’s side, as everyone sat down in the living room. Bow and Micah left after a minute to get some hot cocoa ready and Angella turned to Catra and Adora.

“Micah and I made sure the heater is working in the trailer for you and put some extra towels in there for you as well,” Angella said. “If you need anything, just let us know, please.”

“Thank you again for letting us stay here,” Adora said in her most polite voice and managed not to add ma’am to the end.

“Adora, that trailer would just stand empty if you two didn’t use it,” Angella replied. “It really is alright.”

“I for one would like to say it’ll be nice to sleep in an actual bed and not in the back of a truck. Or the bed of a truck. Or under a truck,” Catra said. “Anywhere near a truck for that matter.”

“You said you were comfortable while you traveled!” Adora said to her. “That sounds awful!”

“I am comfortable,” Catra said. “That doesn’t mean that there’s not a better level of comfort, like beside you.”

Adora blushed hard and glanced at Angella before looking back at Catra with a look that was desperately trying to ask Catra to cut it out. Angella didn’t seem to notice or care, although Glimmer was grinning wide enough for everyone as her mother went on.

“We also stocked the fridge with some drinks and the cabinets with a few snacks so you can have a little privacy if you’d like,” Angella said.

“Did you stock my room?” Glimmer said.

“You can come down to the kitchen,” Angella replied and then suddenly got a little awkward as she looked at Catra and Adora. “You two may as well, of course.”

Adora had immediately thought what Angella was refuting, that she didn’t want them in the house, and she felt herself putting on a fake smile. Catra, however, took it at face value.

“Naw, I got what you meant,” Catra said, giving Adora’s hand a comforting squeeze. “You just want us to be comfortable out there and not have to go out in the cold and dark if we don’t want to, right?”

“Yes, exactly. In fact, we have a big dinner planned tonight for everyone,” Angella said with a relieved smile as Micah and Bow came in with a tray full of hot cocoa and the conversation went forward with questions about school and how the camp was doing in the off-season as well as just general chatter. Bow, Glimmer, and Catra seemed to have no problem keeping up, although Catra was a little quieter but Adora felt weird the whole time and so said almost nothing.

Glimmer’s parents treated them like people, although Adora would have said adults, and Adora wasn’t used to that from older people. When she was younger, at best, she’d been trotted out by her mother like a trained seal for company, to show off a little before being expected to either stay and be quiet or just leave back to her room and not bother anyone. Now, she wasn’t sure how to participate and so she didn’t.

After a little bit, the conversation came to an end as the four went outside to get their stuff. Angella and Micah offered to help but they turned it down. As they went out, Angella stood by the window and watched them head to Bow’s minivan.

“Something on your mind, Angel?” Micah said as he got everything together to take back to the kitchen.

“Just the kids,” Angella replied. “Adora was rather quiet.”

Micah walked over to Angella and put an arm around her as he looked out the window. He could see Adora say something to Catra who smiled back at her and replied.

“Do you think we make her uncomfortable?” Micah said.

“I don’t know. Should we ask her?” Angella said.

“Oh yes, I think that’ll go well if she’s uncomfortable with us,” Micah replied.

“OK, Mr. Sarcastic,” Angella said. “You know what I meant.”

“I did,” Micah said. “Let’s see if an opportunity to address it pops up.”

Angella put her hand around Micah’s shoulder and he leaned into her a little as they watched the kids for a moment longer before he turned and kissed her before going back to taking the stuff into the kitchen.

Chapter End Notes

I did say this wasn't going to be on any kind of coherent update schedule right? Because it really isn't. I appreciate you reading it though!

A few things, first, for those who might not get the joke about Paul, he wrote a good portion of the New Testament of

the Bible. He's also definitely not down with what Catra is attributing to him. He had some things to say about marriage as well that basically says, "It's better not to marry but if you have to because you can't control yourself, then so be it." So yeah, Adora is probably twitching at the incorrectness of it but she gets Catra snuggles so she's distracted.

As to the landscape, places, and such, these are all based on places I know. The places don't align like they do in real life but I could take you to all of them and say, "This is Camp Bright Moon, this is Adora and Glimmer's college, this is Camp Horde for the Lord" and so on. No particular reason that I'm saying this beyond saying that each of these places are known to me and I love writing about them like this.

Anyway, thank you for reading!

# Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora get settled down again in their little home in Glimmer's backyard.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Outside, Bow was getting behind the wheel of the minivan as he said, “I’ll drive it around back so we don’t have to move your boxes all that way.”

“You make it sound like it’s a huge walk back there,” Glimmer said. “It’s no big deal.”

Catra, who’d grown up in foster homes and had never lived in a house with a large yard until she’d stayed in the trailer the summer before, snorted as she said, “To you maybe. I still feel like I need a map and compass to cross your backyard.”

Glimmer rolled her eyes as she said, “The part with the house only sits on about two acres.”

“Only,” Catra said, giving Glimmer a nudge with her elbow.

“Anyway,” Bow said, trying to get back on his point. “Are you going to walk back there or ride with?”

“I’m walking,” Glimmer said. “I’m tired of sitting in the car and someone has to open the fence for you.”

“And keep an eye out for the markings and cairns that mark the trail. Make sure the caches are stocked for us too, will you?” Catra said. Glimmer pretended like she was ignoring her even as she was rolling her eyes as she started walking. Adora followed along and Catra waved to Bow as she followed the other two.

As Adora walked into the backyard, she had a feeling she couldn’t place at first and then suddenly realized it was one of homecoming. She’d felt it before, going back to her mother’s home after camp, but it’d never felt like she felt now. This one felt more exultant and it threw her for a minute to think of being excited about a small cramped travel trailer in someone’s backyard but then she saw Catra making sure the steps up to the door were firm and realized it wasn’t the grandeur of the place but the people who’d be in it.

As they unloaded Adora’s boxes, it quickly became apparent that she’d accumulated more stuff over the last semester than she’d thought she had. When her and Catra had moved into the trailer the previous summer, they’d only had what they could carry as they’d left their old camp but Adora realized that wasn’t the case anymore as they found a place to put all her boxes in the trailer.

“I’m sorry, Catra,” Adora said when they’d finally finished. “I didn’t fully realize how much stuff I had until now.”

Catra shrugged as she reached into the back of the minivan and grabbed two big canvas duffle bags.

“No problems. I’m still traveling light,” Catra said with a grin as Adora thought she heard some metallic clanking coming from one of the bags.

“If you two want, I think Bow and I can get my stuff up to my room on our own,” Glimmer said. Bow was about to protest when Glimmer shot him a raised eyebrow with a little smile.

“Yeah, we can handle it,” Bow said with a smile. “You two get settled in.”

“You sure?” Adora said. “I don’t want to leave you in the lurch.”

Catra sat a hand on Adora’s arm as she said, “Sure, you two go on.”

“You sure?” Adora said.

“They’re sure,” Catra said. “Come on and let’s get settled.”

Adora wanted to argue but Glimmer had already jumped in the front seat and Bow was assuring them it was fine so she went on inside.

"I feel bad not helping her," Adora said as Catra went down the narrow walkway to the bedroom in the back of the travel trailer.

"Adora, they wanted some alone time," Catra said as she sat her bags down on the bed with another clank.

"What do you mean… *oh,"* Adora said. Catra turned around to see Adora blushing hard.

"That never stops being cute," Catra said with a grin as she sat down on the bed. Adora went on back and sat down on the bed beside Catra, her arm immediately finding its way around her.

"Can I ask you a question?" Adora said.

"Sure."

"Why is your bag clanking?"

Catra suddenly laughed as she scooted over on the bed a little bit and picked up one of her bags.

"Remember I was telling you about making tools?" Catra said as she undid the top of the bag and started pulling stuff out.

"You're carrying your tools around with you?" Adora said and then felt silly as she realized that being a traveling farrier meant being able to do just that.

"Yep," Catra said as she pulled out an oddly shaped hammer and handed it to Adora. "Here's the first one I made as a matter of fact."

Adora looked at the wooden handle and then at the hammer itself and even though she didn't really know much about tools, she felt like something was different about this one. Nothing was particularly neatly finished but it still felt solid and capable.

"So you said you made this," Adora replied as she turned the hammer over. "Like, made it? By hand?"

"Yep, made as in I took a block of steel and turned it into that head," Catra said with a grin as she pulled her hoodie off. "Reggie helped of course but yeah, I made that and then he helped me make the handle for it. It's hickory from some wood he cut on his place. I've got some tongs in the bag as well as some other stuff I've made."

“That’s so cool,” Adora said as she handed the hammer back to Catra and then noticed Catra’s arms. They’d always been strong arms but now that they were out of the hoodie, she saw how well defined the muscles on them were, which caused her to blush again.

“Are you blushing over my hammer!?” Catra said with a laugh as she took it back.

“No!” Adora said.

“Come on, you can tell me,” Catra said, giving Adora a little nudge.

“I just, ummm… your arms,” Adora replied in a whisper as she nodded at them.

Catra looked down and then flexed as she said, “That’s hauling lots of metal, beating on lots of metal, and then of course wrestling with a thousand pound animal that doesn’t want me to change its shoes. Best workout ever!”

Adora reached out and touched one of Catra’s arms and Catra gave her a little smile.

“Glad you didn’t go and haul Glimmer’s bags in for her now?”

“Yes, yes, I am.”

A little while later, Adora was unpacking a few boxes with a smile and a whistle while Catra sat back on the bed. She made sure Adora wasn’t looking as she took a small object wrapped in an old rag out of her bag and then stuck it under her side of the mattress. Catra then got up and stood in the doorway of the bedroom as Adora went through another box. Catra saw that Adora already had her Bible, concordance, and notebook out and tucked on a small shelf above the table.

“Still thinking about being a Religious Studies major?” Catra said, looking at the Bible.

“Yep,” Adora said as she closed the box back up and set it on a small pile towards the front of the trailer. “Still don’t get it, do you?”

Catra sat down at the table with her as she said, “No, I really don’t but that’s fine.”

Adora had been reaching for a box but she stopped and looked at Catra instead.

“Is it?” Adora said quietly.

Catra hesitated but finally said, “Yeah, sure, it’s fine.”

Adora wanted to say that it didn’t sound fine but she also didn’t want an argument and so she smiled and said, “I looked through some of the stuff Glimmer’s parents put in the pantry. There’s not just snacks, they put in some easy dinner stuff.”

“Ooo,” Catra said as she stood up and opened the pantry over the door. “Let’s see what’s in there!”

“Don’t make anything! Dinner is soon,” Adora said.

Catra was already opening a jar of mixed nuts and shaking some into her mouth.

“Trust me, I’m not going to ruin my appetite,” she said, her voice a little muffled as she chewed up the nuts. “I haven’t had a decent meal since we had that Thanksgiving dinner together.”

Adora remembered the little Thanksgiving dinner they’d both attended that the school’s queer/straight alliance had put on for students who couldn’t go home for whatever reason. It’d been nice to spend it with Catra but it’d hadn’t been a feast by any stretch of the words. Adora was about to comment when they both jumped as someone pounded on the door outside.

“The trailer isn’t rocking so I’m knocking!” they heard Glimmer shout.

“She’s in a good mood,” Catra said with a laugh before shouting back, “It’s not locked!”

Glimmer came inside and Adora thought once again about how the trailer was cozy for two who were already friendly but with three or more it became a game of Tetris to move around. Glimmer wedged herself up into a small chair that folded out of the wall up near the front, after moving a few boxes, and said, “Dinners going to be ready in a little bit. Bow’s napping and my Aunt Casta should be here already but she’s running behind.”

“I remember you telling us about her,” Catra said as she held out the jar of mixed nuts to Glimmer who just shook her head. “Isn’t she the one that lives on the commune?”

“She’d say intentional community but yeah, that’s her,” Glimmer said. “She always spends the solstice with Dad.”

“Why the solstice?” Catra said as she put the now half empty jar back up in the cabinet and sat back down on the table.

“She’s pagan, same as Dad,” Glimmer said as if it was the most obvious thing in the world. “That’s Yule for them. Works for me because the way they celebrate it means gifts so I get two gift

giving holidays back to back. I meant to ask Dad if he'd cut the log for this year yet but I haven't had a chance."

Adora took a sudden interest in the table as she tried to think of how to phrase her next question. She'd known about Micah but it wasn't something she really thought about as it wasn't something that seemed to ever pop up in conversation between them. Of course, it wasn't like they'd had frequent conversations but Adora was fighting every old instinct that said what she was hearing was about Satan worship. She very much doubted the family who'd taken her and Catra in and helped them so much were evil but the knee-jerk reaction was there.

"Ah, I see I've made Adora go into one of her moments," Glimmer said, reaching forward to poke Adora.

"Uh, it's nothing, really," Adora said, looking up with a smile.

"Adora, that's your moral dilemma face, we all know it," Catra said, taking Adora's hand and squeezing it. "Is it the devil worship thing?"

"Catra!" Adora said, appalled.

Glimmer burst out laughing as she said, "That's what Mom's mother said when her and Dad first started dating."

“Why the hell would your grandmother say that?” Catra said.

“Grandma was a devout Methodist,” Glimmer said. “She wasn’t fond of Dad at first.”

“I don’t think your family are devil worshippers,” Adora said quickly.

“I didn’t think you thought we were,” Glimmer said, her smile still in place although it looked pasted on as she went on. “Besides, it’s nothing I didn’t hear growing up in a rural school.”

“I never thought about you going to school before,” Adora said. “You never really talk about it.”

“Because it sucked. I mean, I loved that I got to grow up here at the camp but grade school blew because I went to school in Oak Springs,” Glimmer said, referring to the nearest town to the camp. “Some of the teachers looked down on me because of Dad but screw them. High school was better because Oak Springs couldn’t support one and I got to go to Rogers. Not that I didn’t get some assholes there as well but it wasn’t as bad. Kind of lonely sometimes but probably everyone has that issue at high school.”

“I’m so sorry,” Adora said, feeling guilty because she knew she’d probably have done the same to Glimmer at one point not that far back. Glimmer shrugged but Adora could tell she was still bothered by it, even though she was still smiling.

“You know what? It’s over,” Glimmer said and her smile was suddenly bigger. “I have an awesome boyfriend, friends, and I’m home from my first semester of college. I never have to talk to those assholes ever again.”

Catra gave a little salute at Glimmer as she said, “I’m absolutely down for that.”

Adora looked at Catra as she said, “There’s no one you’d want to see again?”

Catra shrugged as she said, “Nope, not really. I never really had friends. I mean, I had people I’d kind of hang out with and talk with and stuff but no one was ever a really close friend, not like you were. I mean, a lot of kids moving in and out of the home I stayed at meant I never really had anyone around long term to be friends with and my foster parents sure as shit weren’t going to be my friends. Church wasn’t any better. I was the poor charity case to be pitied at best. Believe it or not, camp was probably my most stable environment.”

Glimmer’s eyes got a bit bigger as she said, “Camp Horde for the Lord was your *stable* environment!?”

“Yes, Sparkles, it was,” Catra said. “Why do you think I put up with it?”

“Uh, duh, for Adora of course,” Glimmer said, “and why Sparkles!?”

Catra looked meaningfully at Glimmer, who was wearing a jacket with sequins all over it as well as glitter eye shadow before grinning and saying, “Oh, I don’t know. Just felt right.”

Glimmer huffed, trying not to smile, as Catra went on.

“And yeah, of course Adora but I liked Scorpia, Kyle, and Rogelio as well,” Catra said. “I’m not saying I want to go back to that but it wasn’t all awful. It had its moments. Like seeing Adora scream defiance in the face of an asshole. That was awesome.”

“I didn’t scream,” Adora said, blushing. “I stated my case.”

“Adora, we could hear you from where Bow and I were sitting on the river,” Glimmer said.

“You could not!” Adora said, laughing despite herself. The memory of facing down Joshua, the man who ran Camp Horde for the Lord, when she and Catra had just confessed their love for each other, was still a complicated feeling for her but tucked into the warm trailer with Glimmer and Catra, she felt like she could laugh at least.

“Well, not really but it would have been awesome if we had,” Glimmer said.

“Your loss,” Catra said. “It was great!”

Adora was about to change the subject when a shout from outside changed it for her.

“Glimmer! Get out here and come see your aunt that you never bother to visit, call, or write!” a voice shouted good-naturedly from the back yard.

Glimmer rolled her eyes again but a little smile played across her lips as she said, “Ah, Aunt Casta is here. Come on, let's go meet her.”

Chapter End Notes

I think this is the first time I’ve ever used the italicized Oh and it was just as delightful as I’ve heard.

# Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra meet Aunt Casta.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora wasn't sure what she was expecting when she walked out the door of the trailer. What she found though was a woman about the height of Glimmer's father, wearing a baggy sweater in muted purple tones, a thin metal headband with a small crystal at the forehead holding back her long black hair, and an ankle length skirt in matching purple tones to the sweater. At first, Adora thought the clothes reminded her of some church women she'd known until Casta stepped forward and Adora caught sight of the biggest, chunkiest boots she'd ever seen on a person. They were scratched up, coated in dust, and had what Adora was pretty sure was some kind of dung stuck to the soles. She heard Catra give a little intake of breath at them and mutter something about how she needed those.

"Oh, Glimmer, look at you!" Casta said as she gave her a hug. "You look fantastic! Not the least bit sick or anything, which I assumed since I've barely heard from you in months."

"Aunt Casta, I talked with you last week," Glimmer said. Her face looked exasperated but her tone was warm. "Besides, if I was sick, you'd be more likely to hear from me."

Casta smiled as she said, “You know I’ll take care of my little Glimmer. Now I’m guessing these are the two I’ve heard so much about.”

“They are,” Glimmer said as she turned, Casta putting an arm around her shoulder as she did. “This is Adora and that’s Catra.”

Adora immediately went into good child mode and stepped forward with her back straight as she said, “Hello, ma’am, I’m Adora. It’s a pleasure to meet you.”

Catra stepped up beside Adora as she said, “And I’m her girlfriend, Catra.”

Adora blushed as Casta smiled at them both and said, “Well, I’m glad you’re here with us for Yule! Are you going to come to the ceremony?”

Adora’s smile froze on her face as she tried to think of a way to respond. On the one hand, she had been brought up not to be rude. On the other, she had an image of dancing naked under the moonlight covered in body paint while chanting strange things to obscene gods. Then she thought of Catra doing that as well and blushed harder as she tried to say something and failed. Catra saved her as she said, “Sure, sounds fun.”

Casta was already looking at Adora with a confused expression before she turned her eyes to Catra and smiled.

“It is! I just talked to Micah and he said he’s got the log ready to go,” Casta said.

“Oh, what is it this year!?” Glimmer said. “I hadn’t had a chance to ask.”

“Cottonwood,” Casta said. “He said he brought down an old tree and it’s quite large.”

“Think it’ll be as big as that one we used from that oak tree that got washed up on the shore by the docks?” Glimmer said.

“Maybe,” Casta said. “Cottonwoods get much bigger around here than oaks do anymore.”

They were interrupted by Micah sticking his head out a door and saying, “You all coming in? Dinner is ready!”

“Oh, that’s right! That’s why I came out here, other than to see my niece for once,” Casta said. “Dinner’s ready.”

“Thanks for the timely update,” Catra said. Adora looked at her in horror for talking back to an adult but Casta just laughed as they all started walking in, Adora hanging back a little as worry ran through her. She relaxed though shortly afterwards as they all sat

down for dinner at a big round table in the dining room. The table was covered in dishes and Catra started rubbing her hands together as she looked over everything.

Normally, Adora would be doing that with her but she was still nervous after the interaction outside. Adora got a glimpse of Casta's socks, dyed wool that matched the sweater, and thought she'd try to compliment her.

"I like your socks, ma'am," Adora said as Casta sat down across from her.

"Do you ma'am a lot?" Casta said and Adora blushed as Glimmer responded.

"Yeah, she does," Glimmer said, nudging Adora under the table with her foot as she smiled at her. "It's alright. She doesn't mean anything by it."

"I don't! I really don't!" Adora said. "I was just raised to be polite."

Micah, who'd met Adora's mother that summer when she'd been threatening him, just cleared his throat as he said, "Casta, did you make those as well?"

"I did," Casta said with a nod. "Juliet and I decided that we were going to try a purple line this year. We did the usual, pokeweed,

mulberry, but we tried a cherry tree root one that was supposed to give a purple hue and it didn't quite turn out. We're still figuring it out."

"Is that what my sweater is this year?" Glimmer said with a grin.

"Now, maybe I didn't make you a sweater this year," Casta said, trying to keep a serious face.

"I'll be happy with whatever you get me," Bow said as he spooned some potatoes onto his plate and passed it to Catra who managed to restrain herself from just glomping half the bowl onto her plate before passing it to Adora. Glimmer stuck her tongue out at Bow and Bow crossed his eyes back at her.

The dinner was warm and open. There was food Adora had never had before, because Casta was, as she put it, "mostly vegetarian" and Micah had cooked to accommodate her. Adora ended up eating everything that had been set out on the table and took seconds and while she didn't talk much, she laughed along with everyone and listened intently the few times the conversation turned serious. When it was all over, everyone helped in clearing the table and Angella had to all but chase Adora out of the kitchen to keep her from washing up.

"Micah and I will handle it just fine," she said. "Go out on the back porch and relax."

Adora finally took the hint and went out to the porch. Glimmer was just putting the light to a large domed adobe wood stove, the dry wood catching quickly in the dry winter air, as Adora sat down on a bench with heavy pillows on it. Catra, already in her hoody, sat down beside her and put her arm around her and Adora leaned into it with a sigh.

Bow patted the recliner he was sitting on and Glimmer went over and lay down beside him, cuddling up next to him as he pulled her in close. Casta stood in front of the door to the stove, holding her hands out to catch the heat. A little bit of light spilled out across the yard from the kitchen but other than that, the fire was the only real light around. Adora looked up into the night sky to see the stars brighter and closer than they seemed in summer. They looked like jeweled points of light in the cold night air, hardly twinkling at all and Adora let out a long sigh, full of tension she wasn't fully aware of and felt herself settle back into the pillows.

"I love being out here after dark," Bow said quietly. "Never get this back in the city."

Casta looked up at the sky with a sigh as she said just as quietly, "You know, I lived in the city a little bit when I was younger, about your age. Hated every minute of it."

"It's got its pleasures," Glimmer said, her voice low.

"Name one," Casta said.

“Pizza at one in the morning,” Catra said, her voice quiet.

Casta gave a little chuckle as she responded, “That’s not fair.”

Adora finally spoke up as she said, “Why are we whispering?”

“We’re not whispering,” Bow said. “We’re speaking in a voice that’s appropriate for the situation. It’s quiet, so we’re quiet.”

“It’s so we don’t attract the Boogie Man,” Catra said, tickling Adora a little. Adora pulled Catra’s hand away with a little laugh while Bow and Glimmer both laughed. Casta though, she didn’t laugh.

“Now you know you should be respectful of the woods,” Casta said. “There’s more out there than we fully understand.”

Adora looked at her, wondering what in the world she was talking about, when Bow spoke up.

“I remember you telling me that a couple years ago. Had me looking over my shoulder every time I was out at the archery field at sundown for a while,” Bow said.

“I’m not trying to scare you but you gotta watch out. You hear something like a screaming child in the dark, go the other way,”

Casta said. “Somethings trying to lure you in.”

Glimmer snorted as she said, “Yeah, a cougar, which pretty much don’t exist around here.”

Casta shook her head as she said, “You should know better, you grew up out here.”

“And I spent a lot of time running around the woods at all hours,” Glimmer said. “Never saw a spirit, specter, or cougar for that matter, in all that time.”

Casta shook her head but Adora could see a smile in the dim light of the fire.

“Just heed my words,” Casta said.

“Yes, Aunt Casta,” Glimmer said in a sing-song voice.

“Do you… really think there’s spirits out in the woods?” Adora said.

Casta looked at her and didn’t respond at first. She’d talked with Micah and knew Adora’s background, and had told him she wouldn’t put up with being preached at, but Adora’s question

seemed more searching than inquisition style. Casta sat back on the small bench molded into the clay body of the oven as she responded.

"I do," Casta said. "I know Glimmer is rolling her eyes at me right now but that's alright. I believe everything is alive, everything has a spirit, and everything is connected. And that means that yes, I think there are spirits in the woods and not all of them are well meaning. Not wise to meddle with them if you don't know what you're doing. Well, even when you do know to be honest."

Adora wasn't sure what to say. She'd been taught that God was in all things, that He saw everything, was everything, and what Casta was saying fit that except for the spirit part. God wasn't evil. Satan was evil and worked against the Lord's plan but a good Christian had the ability to handle his evil works as well as his demons in the name of God.

"And that's why we spend an entire night in the woods around a fire pit on the solstice. To taunt the spirits with our tasty, tasty flesh," Glimmer said.

"Now, you know that's not why," Casta said with a little laugh. "And I never heard you complain."

"That's a lie and you know it," Glimmer said. "Remember that one year it freaking *snowed!?"*

“I found that year beautiful!” Casta said. “But you’re right, tease your aunt, you did complain.”

“Wait, why do you do that on the solstice then?” Adora said, jumping in.

“Oh, I know!” Bow said, sitting up a little.

Casta was smiling as she said, “I’d like to know what Glimmer told you.”

“I told him the correct thing,” Glimmer said.

“She did, Aunt Casta,” Bow replied. “It’s to remember the old year that’s passing and the new that’s to come. It’s also the longest night of the year and it’s to welcome back the Sun and to know that the winter won’t last forever.”

“Well, you did tell him correctly,” Casta said and Glimmer gave her a smug look in return. “We do that with a night long vigil as we burn the Yule log.”

“Sounds kind of fun,” Catra said. “Kind of cold though. You know fireplaces exist inside homes you could sit around.”

“It’s not so bad,” Glimmer said. “We bundle up and bring blankets. Besides, I think the firepit thing is a my family thing.”

“It is,” Casta said. “Micah and I started doing it, really loved it, and kept doing it.”

The patio got a little darker as the lights inside went out and they all vaguely saw Micah and Angella come out the back door.

“Heard my name. Everyone comfy?” Micah said as he and Angella settled into another bench as Angella sat a large covered cast iron pan on the table beside her.

“Yep,” Glimmer said. “We were just telling Adora a little bit about the whole Yule night thing.”

“I’m excited for this year!” Micah said as Angella smiled at him and squeezed his hand.

“You’re excited every year, sweetheart,” she said.

“Because it’s so great,” Micah said, a big smile on his face. “We get to do the ritual, then we get to all sit around the fire with friends and family and have snacks and tell stories and I mean, what’s not to love!?”

Adora twitched a bit at the ritual part but the rest, the rest sounded like fun. In fact, it reminded her of campfires she'd been at when she was in summer camp.

"Are Spinne and Tossa going to make it this year?" Glimmer asked.

"No, they're going to Spinne's family," Angella said.

"Hey, I meant to ask, how did those two get their nicknames?" Catra said.

"What makes you think they're nicknames?" Glimmer said.

"Spinneralla and Netossa? Really? Those aren't nicknames?" Catra said.

"Don't be too quick to assume things," Casta said. "You know my full name is Castaspella, right?"

"I mean, yeah, I guess Glimmer might have mentioned that," Catra said with a shrug. "Didn't think about it though."

"Well, it's good to think about. Names mean something after all," Casta said.

Bow was nodding slowly as he stared into the fire and quietly said, “They do. They mean *everything.”*

Catra glanced over at Bow as the whole circle went quiet. Bow looked up, not realizing just how intense he’d responded, with a confused look on his face.

“What?”

“Got a little intense there for a moment,” Catra said with a grin.

Bow looked around, about to apologize when he shook his head with a little smile as he said, “Well, you know, it’s a thing for me.”

Catra nodded as she said, “I completely understand. I mean, I’m planning on never going by Catrina ever again if I can avoid it.”

Adora looked at her. She’d never heard Catra say this before but it didn’t surprise her. She hugged her a little tighter and Catra looked towards her, her eyes in shadow from the flickering firelight coming from the stove but her smile shone in the light.

Bow spoke up then as he said, “I hate to break this thread but Angella, did I see you bring out a skillet?”

Angella smiled as she picked up the heavy skillet with both hands as she said, “I did. Cinnamon apples tonight.”

The following minutes were followed with people getting up and helping get everything ready. Casta managed the fire, getting everything pushed around inside the oven so they could put the pan inside, while Glimmer and Micah pulled a round table over to them so they could set the pan on it when it was done. The rest chattered about little things and the evening went along. Later, after Micah had sat water inside the pan and put it back in the oven to heat up and help clean the pan, Glimmer and Bow followed Catra and Adora back to the trailer and it was just Micah, Angella, and Casta sitting on the patio.

They were all quiet, watching the stars, and Casta reached inside of her sweater and pulled out a flask. She unscrewed the lid and held it out to the other two.

“First pull?” she said.

“That’s not your special brew is it?” Micah said, raising his eyebrow.

“Think I’m wasting that on you?” Casta said with a grin. “Besides, I don’t need you trying to cast spells in your boxers in the middle of the yard again. Naw, this is just my latest run through the still. This one’s peach. Got a bunch from the orchard down the road this summer.”

Angella smiled as she shook her head. She made a point of avoiding Casta's moonshine.

"I'll pass, thank you."

Micah leaned forward and took the flask from her and took a quick swig. His eyes went wide as he handed it back to Casta.

"I was going to tease you but that's actually really good," Micah said. Casta took a swig before screwing the flask shut and sliding it back into her sweater.

"Juliet chopped up a bunch of the less appealing looking peaches and we soaked the run in it," Casta said.

"And how is Juliet doing?" Angella said.

"She's fine," Casta said.

"You two seemed pretty close the last time we came to visit," Angella said.

“Well, you know, we’re good friends,” Casta said, looking between the two.

“Angie is trying to be subtle. I’m your big brother so I’m not going to bother. Why haven’t you told us you two are an item?” Micah said.

“An item? Really? You run a summer camp, you think you’d be more up on slang at least,” Casta said.

“He prefers to learn the slang and then misuse it around the kids,” Angella said with a laugh.

“And I’m not letting either one of you change the subject,” Micah said. “I saw two toothbrushes the last time I was at your place. Come on. Are you together and if so, why the secret?”

Casta sighed as she reached inside her sweater and pulled the flask out again.

“Are you really that embarrassed?” Angella said. Casta took another swig before answering.

“No,” Casta said. “Neither is Juliet before you ask. We just, well, you’ve both lived in a tiny community like that. You know how everyone is about everyone else’s business. Juliet and I just wanted it to be private for a while.”

“You could have told us, you know,” Micah said. “We would have kept it quiet. Why didn’t you bring her? Is that why?”

Casta shook her head as she said, “No, she had something she said she had to do.”

Casta looked down as she said it and Angella leaned forward and placed a hand on Casta’s shoulder.

“I’m sorry. You really wanted her to come, didn’t you?”

Casta nodded before looking up.

“It’s alright,” she said. “I’ll see her soon enough.”

Angella squeezed Casta’s shoulder before reaching down and taking the flask from her. Casta looked up in surprise as Angella took a sip and grimaced as the fiery liquid raced down her throat.

“That’s…,” Angella said before coughing a little and shaking her head like a dog with a bug in its ear. “That is pretty peachy.”

Casta laughed as she took the flask back and said, “I’ll make sure and get you a pint of your own.”

Angella, just smiled as best she could as she coughed again, shaking her head.

Chapter End Notes

I was going to have Casta, where she reveals her full name, say something like, “Don’t be too quick to assume things,” and then say she knows someone named like Moondust or whatever and then it occurred to me that she’s named Castaspella. So I just used her name instead.

Also, Bow answering something WAY too intensely for the conversation is something I have a habit of doing.

# Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

Catra wakes up the next day with a question in her head.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra was staring at the ceiling of the little trailer, warm under a blanket, as she tried to figure out why she was awake. She turned her head to look out the window but between the frost on the window and the dark, she didn't really see anything. When she checked the clock by the door, she saw it was going to be dark for a little while longer. She lay there, trying to go back to sleep, and finally realized she was up because this was the normal time she'd been getting up during her time working.

Catra got out of bed, kissing Adora's arm that was thrown across her as she did, and got dressed. She leaned against the wall for a moment, looking at the dim outline of Adora lit by the light from the digital clock before going to the front of the trailer to quietly get her shoes on. She didn't think she ever heard Adora's breathing even shift as she stood up to go outside. She'd gotten way to used to moving around quietly when she was living with her foster family. Not seen meant not thought of and she had preferred it that way.

In the dim light cast by the light of the microwave's clock, Catra saw the shelf that Adora kept her Bible study stuff on. Looking back towards the bedroom, she saw that Adora was still asleep and carefully took the notebook down. She immediately saw it was a different one from the one she'd been writing in over the summer. It had the logo of her university on it and she'd written something on the cover. Catra leaned towards the microwave and brought the cover close to the clock.

By the light of the clock, she could read that it said it was a study journal and had a beginning date on it in Adora's neat handwriting. Catra looked back at Adora and saw she was still sleeping. She wanted to know what was in that notebook because even though she trusted Adora, there was a little nagging feeling that said she only thought she trusted Adora. She looked down at the notebook and thought about how she could know for sure. She knew Adora was with her. She knew Adora had given up so much but that little bit of her nagged at her that she would have given up this as well if she'd cared so much. Catra remembered people all her life telling her she was a sinner, Hell-bound, that she needed to repent or be a better person and they all backed it up with Bible verses, even the ones who hit her.

What in the hell does she see in this crap? Catra thought, her hands gripping the notebook tight before finally shoving it back where she'd found it. As she quietly let herself outside, she felt like she was running from something and she felt guilt wash over her because in the end she hadn't put it back out of respect for Adora's privacy, she'd put it back out of fear of what she might find out.

Catra found herself walking out into the main part of the camp, missing Reggie, the man she was learning the farrier trade from, and his early morning coffee. He was an older man, quiet for the most part but a good listener with solid advice who joked his coffee was terrible. Catra wouldn't say it was terrible but it certainly wasn't fantastic either. What it was good at though was getting a person up and moving in the morning and she missed having a hot mug of it. She thought things were a little more simple with a mug of coffee in her hand.

She wandered through the arts and crafts pavilion, everything neatly cleaned and put away in weatherproof cabinets or into storage for the winter. The benches and tables that normally sat in there were all stored away in a large barn elsewhere on the property and the large open space in the early morning gloom felt melancholy to Catra. She headed on to the river, pulling her hoody a little closer against the damp chill in the air as she approached

the river and as she came over a little rise, she caught a look at Camp Horde for the Lord across the river.

“What in the hell?” she muttered to herself. On the cliff top across the river, where the main buildings for that camp sat, she could see a huge cross with color shifting lights on it. She watched as the color slowly shifted from red to purple before she squeezed her eyes shut and shook her head. She’d thought about sitting and watching the river for a little bit but having the gaudy cross in view just killed that idea, so she turned around and headed back towards the trailer.

When she walked into the backyard, the sky had brightened as the Sun was just starting to peek itself over the horizon. She stopped though when she saw Casta in the middle of the yard, arms stretched to the sky before she slowly bent over in a bow. Catra felt weird, like she’d caught someone doing something vaguely embarrassing, and stood there for a second, trying to figure out what to do or say.

“Just going to stand there and stare?” Casta said as she almost folded herself in half at the waist.

“Ummm, no, just didn’t want to, uh, interrupt your prayer or worship or whatever,” Catra replied. Casta straightened up and turned around. Catra couldn’t help but notice the little amused smile on her face.

“Why did you think I was doing that?”

Catra shrugged as she said, “You’re bowing to the Sun.”

Casta walked over as she said, “I’m doing yoga. I mean, that was the Sun Salutation pose but it’s not worship for me.”

Catra felt her face get hot at the misunderstanding as she said, “Oh, OK, whatever.”

“I’m a little surprised you're up this early,” Casta said as she clamped her hands behind her back and stretched a little.

“Figured teenagers slept in.”

“Yeah, well, this teenager has been doing hard work for the last few months and I wake up early,” Catra said.

“OK, didn’t mean to offend,” Casta said as she held up both hands as if warding something off. “I got some coffee ready if you want some.”

Catra immediately said, “You drink coffee?”

Casta grinned some more as she said, “You’re kind of prickly first thing, I see, and yes, I drink coffee. Why wouldn’t I?”

“Because, I don’t know, healthy living, eating, the vegetarian thing, um, I’ll shut up now,” Catra said as she saw Casta trying not to laugh.

“Yeah, I eat healthy but everything in moderation, including moderation,” Casta said. “You want that coffee or not?”

“God, yes, please,” Catra said. Casta laughed and the two went into the kitchen where Casta poured out two cups. Catra sat at the kitchen table that looked out over the side yard of the house and took a deep breath of the steam coming off the coffee.

“I love electric coffee makers,” Casta said as she sat down across from Catra. “I live off grid, no electricity at my place, and you’d think I’d miss stuff like lights or A/C but nope, coffee maker, that’s what I miss.”

“Guy I work for, Reggie, he makes it in a big coffee pot over a Coleman stove,” Catra said. “You end up with a little bit of the grounds in his.”

“Ah, cowboy coffee style,” Casta said with a nod.

“Yeah, that’s what he called it,” Catra replied. She took a sip of the coffee and sighed a little as the warmth spread out in her chest. She was right, things were a bit simpler with some coffee in hand.

“So, college not your thing?” Casta said as she settled in at the table. Catra looked at her over the cup, trying to gauge why she was asking. Catra had never been really excited about college but it’d been something the counselors at school had pushed on her, one of them flat out telling her she’d be a failure if she didn’t attend, and from other interactions with adults up until recently, that had always been the feeling she got from them.

“Guess not,” Catra said with a shrug. “I’m enjoying the whole farrier thing.”

“Good,” Casta said. “I’m proud of Glimmer for going but I think more kids need to get out there and try other stuff. Not everything is a college degree.”

“Says the person with a masters in botany,” Micah said as he walked into the kitchen yawning and scratching at his beard. His fuzzy pink slippers made little shuffling noises against the hardwood floor as he stopped in front of the coffee pot and filled a cup up as Casta responded.

“That means I know what I’m talking about,” Casta said before turning to Catra. “Way I see it, you have two kinds of knowledge in this world.”

Catra saw Micah roll his eyes behind his sister as he leaned into the cabinet but he was smiling as he did it. Casta went on, as she tapped her head.

“There’s the kind up here,” she said and then she held out her hands and Catra saw that they were splotchy with multiple shades of faded purple from dye baths and a few scars. “And there’s the kind that’s here. You’re going to need both.”

“You forgot the kind that’s here,” Micah said as he thumped his chest over his heart.

Casta turned to her brother then with a matching roll of her eyes as she said, “She swam through a flooded river with her girlfriend, I think she knows that one already.”

Catra almost choked on her coffee at that and both Micah and Casta turned to her as she cleared her throat.

“You know about that?” Catra said, turning several shades of red.

“Don’t be embarrassed,” Casta said. “It’s a wonderful story.”

Catra thought about how earlier she’d been doubting Adora and now Casta was saying what a great story the whole thing was. She had to admit, Adora had jumped into a flooded river to save her. She remembered telling Adora to go, save herself, that it didn’t matter but Adora had just held her tight.

Why am I doubting her? Catra thought.

Because impulse isn’t the same as long term, she answered herself. She took another drink of her coffee before answering out loud.

“It’s a wonderful relationship,” Catra said.

Micah nodded as he took a sip, looking at Catra as he did. They all chatted about a few inconsequential things after that before Catra got up to go back to the trailer. As she made her way across the yard, she heard someone behind her and looked over her shoulder to see Micah behind her.

“What?” Catra said.

“Are you two having problems?” Micah said with a nod towards the trailer.

“No, we’re fine,” Catra said and she felt like it came out a little too fast even as she felt herself tensing up.

“OK,” Micah said. “Let me know if you need anything.”

With that he went back inside. Catra watched him go, trying to figure out what his ploy was for a moment, before shaking her head and going back to the trailer. Once in the trailer she saw

Adora stretched out in the bed, her hand making little jabbing motions as if she was punching at something in her sleep. Catra shook her head with a little grin as she went over to wake her up.

Adora woke up to Catra giving her a kiss on her hand. She sat up groggily, the early morning sunlight melting the frost on the windows as she looked around.

“Hey,” Catra said as she leaned forward to give her a proper kiss.

Adora had a goofy smile on her face after the kiss as she said, “Hey, you taste like coffee.”

“I’ve been up for a little bit,” Catra said. “Couldn’t sleep. I ran into Casta; she’d made some coffee.”

Adora stretched before curling around Catra.

“I missed this,” she said.

Catra looked down at her, a content smile on Adora’s face, and felt bad for doubting her even while the little thought still nagged at her mind.

“I did as well,” Catra said as she found herself absentmindedly fiddling with Adora’s hair, her undercut from the previous summer already fairly long.

“Well, I better get up and get the day going,” Adora said after a few minutes. “I’m already behind schedule.”

Catra grinned suddenly to see Adora go from relaxed to active as she got out of bed and made her way to the shower.

“You’re on vacation, you know that right?” Catra asked.

Adora nodded as she went into the tiny bathroom.

“Doesn’t mean I can slack off.”

As the door slid shut, Catra found herself laughing.

“That’s exactly what that means, goofball!”

Chapter End Notes

I can not believe I haven't updated this since early October. Things have been... interesting for me. I just had a hard time finding time and motivation to write a lot and this unfortunately was one of the fics that suffered. That's odd because I actually wrote a whole other series between the last time updated this and now. Also, I *hate* leaving an unfinished fic or missing self imposed deadlines. This one I expected to actually have done before Christmas but as we can see, that didn't happen. Anyway, I'm back on this and while it is probably going to be a bit random on updates, hopefully it won't be over two months before the next one. Thank you for reading and I hope you enjoy this!

# Chapter 6

Chapter Summary

Catra can't help but feel like she's not being put first but Adora doesn't quite realize that yet.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The next few days were the nicest that Adora could remember since the summer. If she was being honest with herself, it was even nicer because she didn't have any work to do and she was spending the time with her best friend who was also her girlfriend and she was with her other two best friends. She got to see Swift Wind and ride some, they'd hung out in Glimmer's room and talked for hours, and she'd spent some time every day reading and thinking.

As for Catra, she was beginning to realize something. She'd been lonely her whole life and now she found herself with friends, real friends, and she had to admit it felt good. Although every afternoon, when the two couples would separate for a little quiet time together, she still frowned a little as Adora pulled down her notebook and Bible and did some reading before coming back and cuddling up with her. Finally, she had to ask.

"What are you reading today?"

Adora didn’t answer at first. It took her a few seconds to stop, make a note, and then answer her.

“Romans twelve right now,” Adora said as she sat back at the little table.

Catra couldn’t help herself as she said with a grin, “How about you come over here and get your figures to roamin’?”

Adora blushed as she said, “Uh, in just a second. I mean, I’d love to but let me finish this real quick, ok?”

Catra sat up from where she had been sprawled out on the bed as she said, “Are you serious? I just said come over here and make out with me and you seriously want to finish up a Bible verse?”

Adora looked away as she said, “It’s not the verse. I just wanted to write something down. I’m sorry.”

Adora shut the Bible and the notebook and put them away before coming back and sitting down on the bed.

“Don’t act like it’s a big favor or something,” Catra said. “It’s not like we’ve hardly seen each other over the last few months or anything.”

“I don’t want to fight,” Adora said. “I came back here like you wanted.”

“That’s the problem, Adora,” Catra said. “Like I wanted. Don’t you want it too or are you too tied up in that book?”

“Yes, like I want, alright?” Adora said. “Do we really have to argue about this?”

“Yeah, I kind of think we do,” Catra said and then stopped as Adora leaned down and kissed her.

“You sure?” Adora said, her face close to Catra.

“OK, later,” Catra said as she wrapped her arms around her and kissed her again.

Later found them on the back porch of the house, everyone around the fireplace. One thing Adora was getting used to was how much time that Glimmer’s family seemed to spend outside. She remembered during the summer that it seemed like they were hardly ever inside but Adora had thought she could chalk that up to the fact they ran a summer camp. Now, near the beginning of winter, they still did the same thing and while it was still odd, she had to admit she enjoyed it, even if she did get a bit chilled occasionally.

“I just got word that my next batch of yarn is getting bought out again,” Casta said as she carefully dipped a piece of fry bread into some honey next to her.

“Is it that one shop that’s in Delhucha?” Angella asked.

“That’s the one,” Casta said. “I love when they buy me out. They pay better.”

“I thought you swore you would never sell to her again. I thought she did some of your friend’s dirty,” Micah said.

“She did but they settled it with her. She was trying to be all, ‘Oh, my word is my bond’ and ‘We’re all good Christians here.’ They managed to get what they owed out of her and now pretty much none of us locals will deal with her without an actual written contract,” Casta said before she snorted. “I told them they should have known better. Person brags that hard about their religion when doing business, they should have held onto their wallets tighter.”

Casta took another bite of her bread as everyone else tried not to look at Adora. As for Adora, she was grabbing a piece of fry bread as well and didn’t notice the sudden quiet at first. Then she looked up.

“What? Was I not supposed to have thirds?” Adora said, leaning forward as she held Catra’s hand with one hand while the other

hand hovered above a basket nestled up near the entrance to the fireplace.

Casta said, “I think they’re all uncomfortable because I implied that people who are religious and brag about it in business are crooked.”

Adora shrugged as she put her hand into the basket and grabbed another piece of bread as she said, “My mother always did say it was unseemly to make a big display.”

“Isn’t this the woman who had Bible verses all over the back of her car?” Catra said.

Adora looked at her, not having forgotten the little argument from earlier, as she said quietly, “Yeah, it is.”

Everyone got quiet again. Casta simply chewed on her bread and finally Micah started to speak at the same time Adora did. They both stopped and then started to speak again.

“Sorry, you go ahead,” Micah said.

Adora was shaking her head, embarrassed that she’d interrupted an adult, as she said, “No, sorry. Go ahead, sir, er, I mean, Micah.”

Micah gave her a crooked grin as he shook his head and said, "Nope, you called me sir. You have to speak first now."

Adora twisted her hands together in discomfort as she said, "Listen, I know that people use their faith in twisted ways. You don't hurt my feelings by pointing that out, Casta."

Casta slowly took the flask out of her pocket with a nod as she watched Adora.

"Also, I'm not completely blind," Adora said as she looked up, her back straightening a little as she looked at Catra. "I know my mother is a hypocrite. That doesn't make everything she said a lie."

Casta took a sip and capped the flask, leaning forward with it held between her hands.

"I was just pointing it out," Catra said.

"I know. You do that. A lot," Adora replied, her tone sharp.

The whole group went quiet again as Catra shifted a little in her seat. Catra and Adora still held the other's hand but they seemed to be far apart at the moment.

“I’m sure she doesn’t mean anything by it,” Bow said.

“Yeah, it was nothing,” Catra said, looking away from Adora as she said it.

Micah spoke up with a chuckle as he said, “I was going to say that people’s beliefs get away from them when money gets involved. It’s not unique to Christians.” He looked at Angella as he went on. “Remember that one group that tried to set up a New Age retreat up the road?”

Angella shook her head as she said, “Yeah, that.”

Glimmer was laughing as Bow, eager to get the conversation to something funny, asked, “I haven’t heard about this. What’s so funny?”

Casta was rolling her eyes as Micah leaned in a little as he began to tell the story.

“OK, so these two quarter sections up the road came up for sale about five, was it five, yeah, never mind, about five years ago. Anyway, everyone wanted it. The road access isn’t great, the county still hasn’t paved up there, but the property was wonderful. Three hundred and twenty acres or so and it had good grazing pastures by the road, good river bottom land with a deep

creek running through it to the river that never dried up, and it'd been unattended long enough there were some nicely forested spots on it as well. The kicker was the owner had been elderly, died, the kids had moved away years ago and the county was about to seize it and auction it for back taxes. People were *drooling. "*

Glimmer grinned as she said, "I seem to remember you doing the same."

"He was not drooling," Angella said.

"I was but not enough to be interested because we have more than enough land here and that's the kind of situation that causes generations long blood feuds between people," Micah said with a chuckle.

"Wait, blood feuds are really a thing?" Catra said.

"Better believe it," Casta said. "Surprised you haven't run into it yet in your line of work."

"Anyway," Micah said, waving his hand to cut them off, "People are counting down the days until the county gets it and it goes up for auction. Then all of a sudden, someone says they heard someone else say that they heard that someone filed a deed for it at the courthouse and the back taxes were paid. A few people checked it out and sure enough, it's been sold and sold for way more than

people were expecting. It went to some LLC, I forget the name, but it was really bland and generic, no hint. People are mad but life goes on. Then a few months later a big sign goes up on the front of the property by the little rickety barbed wire gate. 'Future Home of Gentle Minds Retreat' it said. Had some labyrinth symbol on it, a basic chakra diagram, and I think an ankh or something. Don't remember exactly but anyway, turns out it was some daughter of some big shot in the oil industry who had way more money than sense."

"Now be fair, she had good intentions," Angella said, jumping in. Casta snorted but didn't say anything. Angella looked at her as she went on. "I know most people don't think so but I met her a few times before everything fell apart for her. She seemed a decent person."

"And this is why I married you," Micah said as he picked up Angella's hand and kissed it. "You see the best in everyone."

"Dad, the story?" Glimmer said.

"Ok, fine, we'll canoodle afterwards," Micah said with a little wink at Angella. "Anyway, she had this plan to open this New Age retreat. She was really into it as well. Talked the talk, knew everything about it. I don't doubt she was really into it and she made it happen. Put in some off the wall buildings, cleared some of the land, and so on. Well, the problems began pretty quick.

"She had a bunch of friends who were going to teach little classes and stuff. She collected money for them. She had people book

retreats. Took that money as well. The whole time talking about what a great person she was, how she was honest and upright to keep her karma clean and so on. For a while, it worked. She opened up in the fall and lots of people showed up but then it started falling apart.

"Friends didn't show up to teach. She tried to keep the money or teach the class herself, which didn't work because that's not what people wanted. Weather was nasty that year too, lots of rain in the fall, and the road was a mess down there. People couldn't get in for their retreats and she tried to claim it was their own problem and they didn't cancel per policy. Just stupid stuff like that and she pretty quickly got a rep. That wouldn't be a big deal but she doubled down and started talking about how none of it was her fault and started blaming other people's negative energy and stuff. We all figured her parents would bail her out but rumor is they wanted nothing to do with this and it finally all flopped. Last anyone saw her around here, she was standing in the checkout lane at the grocery store, yelling at a local who'd tracked her down to get payment for something they'd done for her and she was yelling at him about how his energy didn't align with her energy and he needed to clean up his aura and that's why his invoice was 90 days past due."

The little group went quiet for a moment as everyone thought about it and Micah shook his head for a moment as he said, "You know, telling the story now, it's really not that funny. It's kind of sad actually."

Casta grunted as she said, "I guess but it's hard to feel too bad for her knowing she almost drove Chuck to bankruptcy because he did all that construction work and bought all that material on credit for her."

Angella said, “True, but I don’t believe she had bad intentions. She just got in over her head and made bad choices.”

Catra said, “Yeah, but it sounds like she didn’t face up to it and just leaned into the bullshit. You’re right, it’s not really funny but it sure as hell is a cautionary tale.”

“Yeah, I guess so,” Micah said.

The little group talked for a bit longer before it broke up. As the four drifted towards Adora and Catra’s trailer, Bow tried to talk them into going on a hike with him.

“Come on! I know it’s past its peak but the Geminids shower is still going on!” he said as the four stood around outside the door to Adora and Catra’s trailer.

“My boyfriend is a nerd,” Glimmer said with a grin as she threaded her arm through his and leaned into him.

“Your boyfriend is trying to get us to freeze to death,” Catra said.

Bow rolled his eyes as he said, “It’s not even remotely close to freezing.”

“Bow, it dropped below forty while we were sitting on the porch,” Glimmer said. “It’s supposed to be in the high twenties tonight.”

“Yeah, but it won’t hit that until the middle of the night and it’s a pretty still night,” Bow replied. “It won’t be that cold when we’re moving and if we stop, no wind means it still won’t feel that bad.”

Glimmer looked at Adora and said, “Adora, what do you think? You’re pretty quiet.”

Adora didn’t respond at first but when she realized everyone was looking at her, quickly said, “Sure. Let’s do it.”

“Don’t be too excited about it there,” Catra said.

Adora shot her a look but just said, “No, really. It sounds fun. Let’s go.”

Bow didn’t wait and just grabbed Glimmer’s hand as he started backing up.

“I’m with Adora! Let’s go! I know the perfect place!”

“He means the archery range,” Glimmer said, backing up with him. “He always means the archery range when he says that.”

“I do not!” Bow said as he turned around and started walking, his and Glimmer’s hands swinging high as they went.

Adora started following the two without a word and Catra fell in beside her, their hands together but barely moving as they walked.

Chapter End Notes

> Bow trying to talk them into going on a night hike and saying stuff like that they’ll stay warm moving and even if they don’t, there’s no wind is stuff I say to people. Because I’m the person who gets people to go out to the middle of nowhere in the middle of winter to look at the stars because that is the best time because the air is still from the cold and the winter constellations are BRIGHT. I remember once it got down below zero Fahrenheit where I live (rare) and I was standing out on my driveway marveling at how clear I could see the stars.
>
> Anyway, I haven't forgotten about this, it's just going to be an irregularly updating fic for now. Thank you for reading and I hope you enjoy it!

# Chapter 7

Chapter Summary

In the woods of Camp Bright Moon on a winter night, Catra and Adora have a falling out.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The air was sharp as Bow and Glimmer made their way down a path through the woods. Contrary to what Bow had said, they did seem to be moving towards the archery range. Walking a little behind them, Catra couldn't help but think Glimmer looked like she was glowing a little bit in the dark from the puffy pink coat she was wearing.

"You're mad at me, aren't you?" Catra said to Adora, keeping her voice down so Bow and Glimmer couldn't hear them.

Adora glanced over at her before saying, "No. It's fine."

They walked a little further in silence before Catra said, "You can just tell me you know."

"I said it's fine," Adora snipped.

Catra was about to respond when Glimmer said, “I told you he’s taking us to the archery range!”

“I am not!” Bow said, laughing. “If you must know, I’m going to the sports field.”

“Then why are we going this way!?” Glimmer said with a laugh. “This is so out of the way!”

Bow grinned as he responded, “Because of the crack about the archery range. And it’s not out of the way, it just comes at it from the other side.”

Catra looked at Adora, wanting to say something but responded to Bow instead.

“In other words, you were going to the archery range, Glimmer called you on it just now, and you suddenly remembered, ‘Hey! I can get to the sports field this way!’ Fess up, Bow. It’s alright,” Catra said.

“That’s it, isn’t it!?” Glimmer said, turning around and grabbing both of Bow’s hands as she started walking backwards with a little skip. “She’s got your number, doesn’t she?”

Bow said, “Of course she has my number, how else can she call me?”

Glimmer groaned as she said, “That was terrible.”

“I mean, am I wrong?” Bow said as Glimmer got back by his side and they continued walking.

“You know what I mean,” Glimmer said.

“Yes, of course,” Bow said and as Glimmer was ready to say she knew it, he went on. “I mean, a phone number is a pretty common thing.”

“OK, I’m not talking to you,” Glimmer said as Bow got behind her and wrapped her up in his arms.

“Are you really?” Bow said as he rocked them back and forth as they shuffled forward.

“Not talking to you,” Glimmer said and then broke free of his arms and started running. “Unless you catch me!”

She took off down the path as Bow started after her, shouting, “Don’t run in the dark!”

Catra and Adora watched the two disappear down the path and then felt the silence of the winter woods settle in around them. They stopped and waited for them but they pretty quickly realized they'd taken off.

"Should we just go to the sports field?" Adora said, her voice quiet.

"Yeah, I guess," Catra said. "You know the way?"

Adora looked around, trying to get her bearings, before she finally said, "Yes."

Catra looked at her outline in the dark, barely lit by the moonlight trickling through the bare trees, and wasn't so sure but she didn't want to start a fight by asking.

"OK, lead off," Catra said.

Adora nodded and they started walking. Then they promptly got lost.

After they'd been walking for about twenty minutes, Catra finally stopped as she felt the air start to become clammy and realized they were near the river.

“Do you really know where you’re going?” Catra said.

Adora looked at her, a bit annoyed, as she said, “Yes.” Then she got quiet as she looked around and her annoyance leaked away to be replaced by doubt. “No.”

Catra let out a groan as she said, “You seriously got us lost in the woods at night in the freezing cold?”

“Hey! I was following the path! There should have been a turn to the right but it never showed up!” Adora said.

“How do you know!?” Catra said.

“Because I know the path Bow was taking!” Adora said. “As soon as he said where we were going, I knew where we were!”

“So do we go back?” Catra replied.

Adora looked around, hoping to spot some lights from maybe the dock or something like it when she realized that Glimmer’s parents turned off the lighting in the camp during the winter since it wasn’t needed. She deflated a little as she turned to look back up the path and began to doubt that they were on the path that she thought they were on and that maybe Bow had taken them a different way. It was hard to tell in the dark and in a different

season where even during the day familiar places looked slightly out of the ordinary.

"I mean, maybe," Adora said, her voice halting. "They did always tell the campers if they got lost though to just sit still."

Catra walked away from Adora for a few steps while throwing her arms in the air.

"That's because someone will come looking for the kids, Adora! Because the counselors will notice them missing and go into search and rescue mode!" Catra said as she turned back around. "You think anyone is going to notice us missing anytime soon and go into SAR mode or do you think they're going to think we're just off in the bushes making out and not bother until the morning!?"

"Hey, don't get pissed at me!" Adora said. "You've been around here just as much as I have! You could have said something!"

"I did! When we stopped just now! God! I can't believe this!" Catra said as she dropped to the ground next to a big cottonwood tree.

Adora looked down at the ground and kicked at the sandy soil a little before she finally said, "I wasn't trying to get us lost you know. I think I can get us back to the trailer at least."

“How? Are you going to ask your imaginary friend for directions?” Catra said, pointing up into the sky. “Going to get a flaming cloud or some bird or shit to show us the way?”

Adora felt her gut clench tight as she said, “Cut it out.”

“Come on! Just say, ‘Dear God, I went running in the woods and got really lost. Send a magical unicorn bear to lead me home. Amen.’ That’ll work,” Catra said, her voice thick with sarcasm.

Adora just stood there, her hands clenched, before she said, “Fuck you.”

Catra’s eyes widened a little at Adora cursing, especially at her, and was about to say something when Adora started walking fast towards the river.

“Hey, come back here!” Catra said as she scrambled to her feet. Adora was pretty quickly invisible in the shadows under the trees and Catra stood there waiting to see if she’d come back before her anger got the better of her.

“Screw her,” Catra muttered, swiping at a tear. “Can’t believe she’d get mad about that. Just joking.”

She turned around and started back up the path, hoping she’d find the way back without a lot of problems. She kept thinking of

the item she'd stashed under the mattress, that she'd made for Adora and had been planning to give her for Christmas, and wiped harder at her tears as she wondered if it was pointless.

Adora for her part was seething as she stomped along a faint trail that ran along the river. She could see the moon reflected in the surface and was kicking herself for leaving without a flashlight. She'd always told that to every kid she'd ever had under her as a counselor, to be sure they had certain things on them when they went out, and a flashlight was a big item on that list. Of course, she had to admit that the even more important thing she always stressed was never going off alone and she was doing that right then and there. She stopped for a moment as she felt her anger go down a little as she started to tear up.

"Why is it such a big deal?" Adora muttered.

Adora stopped for a moment as she realized she wasn't talking to herself, that she felt like she was praying and then did something unusual. She looked up.

"Why? I want to know why! All those contradictions I'm finding, all those things I'm reading about that are forbidden but no one cares about but this, my love, this is what is wrong!? 'The greatest of these is love' I know you remember that one! It doesn't… I know! I know! I need faith but I can't get her to see that I'm trying to… I don't know! I don't know what I'm doing! I could use a sign, anything, just…," Adora said and then her shoulders slumped. "I just… she means so much to me."

Adora stood there for a moment, being still and hoping for something, before she sighed.

"I figured."

Then she kept walking. She reasoned if she followed the river, she'd run into the camp's dock eventually and then she'd know where she was at and could go back. It wasn't long before she came out of the brush to a stretch of grass with a berm to her right. She stopped and looked around before her eyes caught sight of first the dock, a dim outline against the river and then she spotted the cross at Camp Horde for the Lord, lit up in shifting colors.

Adora moved over to the walkway that led into the dock and set up on the berm to watch the colors. She put her head on her knees as she did and gave a little smile when she realized the cross was shifting through the colors of the rainbow. She watched a meteor streak over the cross and it reminded her of why she was out there at all. She knew she should get up and go back before everyone got worried about her but she couldn't get herself to go as she felt a little peace in the quiet noise of the river while she watched the cross. Then she heard the crunch of gravel underfoot and turned to see Angella walking up to her.

"What do you think of that?" Angella said, nodding towards the cross as she sat down on the path next to Adora.

"It's actually kind of nice," Adora said. "I just realized it's in the colors of the rainbow."

“I noticed that as well,” Angella said. “Micah doesn’t like it. Thinks it’s tacky.”

Adora looked back at what had always been a symbol of hope for her, lit up in the colors of a new symbol in her life, and said, “I can see why he might think that.”

“But you don’t agree,” Angella said.

Adora almost didn’t say anything but replied with, “I don’t.”

The two sat in silence for a moment when Adora heard a muffled crackle of static followed by Glimmer’s voice saying, “Glimmer to all. Catra is with us now. Over.”

Adora looked at Angella as she pulled a small radio from her coat and keyed it up.

“Angella to all. I’m with Adora. We’ll meet you back at the house. Over.”

Adora felt her face go flush as she said, “I didn’t mean to cause a huge ruckus.”

“You didn’t,” Angella said. “Bow and Glimmer came back to the house and said they’d lost you both in the woods. We figured we’d come find you and it looks like we did.”

Adora nodded but didn’t say anything.

“Can I ask why you and Catra weren’t together?” Angella said as she sat down on the path next to Adora.

“We just got separated,” Adora said.

“So it had nothing to do with the tension earlier?” Angella said. Adora turned to look at Angella, her face dim and barely lit by the moonlight.

“We had a fight,” Adora said. “She said some stuff; I got mad and stomped off.”

“Want to talk about it?” Angella replied.

“No,” Adora said. “She’s just mad that I’m still religious. I don’t know. I don’t get it. I’m with her. I’m there for her. We talk all the time but this bothers her.”

“Let me tell you a little something. When my mother married my father, my grandparents were furious. They were pentecostal holiness, do you know what that is?” Angella said and Adora nodded. Angella smiled as she went on. “I thought you might. She didn’t ask for their permission, he didn’t either, and he was Catholic. They thought he worshiped false idols, among other things, and they didn’t talk for a long time. Mom became Methodist and my father eventually did as well. That’s how I grew up.

“When I met Micah, Mom did not like him. She knew he called himself a pagan and did ceremonies and things and thought he was a Devil worshiper. Basically, the same thing her own parents had done but she did something different. She listened to him. She talked with him. Well, they argued is more like it but it wasn’t bad. It was two people wrestling over their beliefs and it turned out the core wasn’t so different. Love each other, take care of each other, and work for a better world. I guess what I’m saying is that I know lots of people with different religious beliefs and that’s how they get along. They find common ground. Even when married.”

Adora watched the cross change to a deep purple as she said, “I just want to know what my life has been up to this point and what it’s going to be.”

“It’s going to be what you want it to be,” Angella said.

“What about Catra? What do I do about that?” Adora said.

Angella put her arm around Adora's shoulder and Adora felt like she'd been enclosed under a protective wing as Angella said, "Adora, I've known the two of you for all of six months. Maybe you're both going to be together forever or maybe, now that things have changed so much for the both of you, it's going to end." Adora felt tears pooling in her eyes at that thought and Angella gave her a little hug. "You won't know until you talk. Both of you, upfront and honest with the other and try to find that common ground. Do you understand?"

Adora nodded as she said, "Yes, ma'am."

Angella chuckled as she said, "You really can't break that habit can you?"

Adora looked over at her as she said, "Because of all the people I've called ma'am in my life, you deserve it the most."

Angella's smile softened as she said, "Thank you, Adora."

The two sat for a moment longer as another meteor streaked across the sky. Angella finally stood up and Adora got to her feet as well.

"Thanks for the advice," Adora said as they began to walk.

“Last bit for now,” Angella said. “When you talk with Catra, don’t do what you think she wants.”

“What do you mean?” Adora said.

“You’re too willing to bend for others,” Angella said. “Be kind but be firm. Alright?”

Adora nodded again and the two walked on through the dark.

Chapter End Notes

I've said before that these places I'm writing about all have real world counterparts and I'm finding myself really nostalgic for the place that Camp Bright Moon is based on as I write this. Anyway, it's becoming a bit more contentious around here. Where shall it go from here?

Thank you for reading!

# Chapter 8

Chapter Summary

Adora walks back with Angella towards the house to meet back up with Catra but what will happen when the two have to be alone?

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora and Angella were halfway to the house when they ran into Casta. Adora jumped and made a little screeching noise as Casta seemed to just appear in front of them on the path.

"Casta, that wasn't nice," Angella said.

"I wasn't trying to do that. It's the purples," Casta said, gesturing at her dark toned clothes. "I just kind of fade away into the shadows. Sorry, Adora. You alright?"

"Yes," Adora said, taking a deep breath before letting out a nervous laugh. "You just kind of looked like a hovering face for a split second."

Casta grinned as she said, "Well, your girlfriend spotted me way sooner."

“She’s got good eyes,” Adora mumbled.

“So you were standing around scaring people,” Angella said.

“No,” Casta said, rolling her eyes. “I heard all the lost sheep were found and came in from my quarter. I just happened to run into Glimmer and her little group and Catra saw me coming. I sent them on back to the house, figured I’d wait here for you two.”

“Well, let’s get on up there ourselves,” Angella said.

Adora walked through the main camp with the two of them. The two were quiet as they walked and Adora kept back a little before Casta threw a look over her shoulder as they went back into the woods.

“You alright?”

“I’m fine,” Adora said.

“You’re not hurt? You just hanging back for your health or what?” Casta said.

Adora shook her head but got up beside the two as she said, “I’m not hurt. I don’t know, I was just thinking.”

Casta said, “Good thing to do. Oh, there’s the house.”

Adora looked forward and through the trees saw the house all lit up. She didn’t think she’d ever seen all the lights on the outside of the house lit up at once. They seemed to glitter a little in their cut glass enclosures and the living room spilled several squares of light out across the lawn.

“Wow,” Adora said quietly.

Angella looked at her and then back at the lights.

“It is pretty nice isn’t it?” she said. “We don’t usually use them but it’s a good way to find it if you’re turned around.”

A few minutes later and Adora was in the living room with the others. Catra was seated on a loveseat and Adora sat down next to her, tentatively taking her hand. Catra wouldn’t quite look at her but she squeezed Adora’s hand tight.

“I’m sorry!” Bow said. “I didn’t think you’d get lost or we would have come back for you!”

“It’s alright,” Adora said. “It’s on me. I must have missed the turn.”

“Well, no harm,” Micah said. “It’s not like it’s easy to get truly lost out here. Just don’t go jumping fences or crossing the river and you’ll at least be on our property.”

“I remember that from this summer,” Adora said with a sheepish grin.

“Well, no more roaming about tonight,” Angella said. “Let’s go ahead and wind it up a little early since it’s been so eventful this evening.”

Angella gave Adora a look that Adora returned with a little nod.

“I agree,” Adora said. “I’m headed to bed. Catra?”

Adora stood from the couch as she looked down at Catra. For her part, Catra managed to look up and nod before she got up as well. The two headed out the back of the house as Micah looked at Angella.

“It’s not even 8:30 yet,” Micah said.

Angella watched where they’d gone as she said, “It’s alright. They need some rest I think. Eventful night, like I said.”

Micah shrugged as Glimmer and Bow drifted up to her room.

Out in the yard, neither one spoke as they crossed over to the trailer. Adora opened the door and gave a little hand gesture at Catra who walked in and turned the heater up a little. Adora came in and shut the door tight, locking it before turning on the little light over the table.

“Listen, what I said earlier, I uh, I didn’t…,” Catra started to say before Adora cut her off.

“Stop. You meant it,” Adora said, facing the door before turning around. In the close space, Catra was right in front of her, less than an arm’s length away. Adora crossed her arms as she looked away from her. “I know you were mad but you meant it. Didn’t you?”

Catra started to say she didn’t but sighed instead as she leaned against the wall next to her.

“Do you really want to do this?”

Adora looked over to her and saw her eyes wet and shiny.

“I do,” Adora whispered. “We need to talk about this.”

“Listen, I get mad and say stupid shit,” Catra said. “You know this. Just, you know, let it go. I’m sorry.”

“I can’t,” Adora said. “I want to, you have no idea how bad, but I can’t.”

Adora sat down at the table and as she did, she reached up and took down her Bible. Catra looked away, her hand coming up to angrily wipe away the tears that threatened to run down her face.

“Don’t,” Catra said. “Don’t you dare quote that fucking thing at me.”

Adora placed her hand on it as she said, “I’m not going to preach at you. Do you know me?”

Catra looked at her as she said, “Of course I know you.”

“Do you?” Adora said and her voice cracked a little. “Because I don’t.” Tears began to run down her face as she went on. “I thought I was one thing for so long and then I just… everything changed.”

Catra took a step forward and knelt down beside the table as she put a hand on Adora's leg.

"You're still you," Catra said. "You're truly yourself now, not that facade you put up for all those years. This is you."

Catra patted her leg as she said it and Adora gave a crooked smile as she wiped at her eyes and patted the Bible.

"So is this," Adora said and she saw the look on Catra's face. "I'm not looking for a reason not to be with you. I love you, you're a part of me, but so is this and it can't all be bull."

"Yes, it can," Catra said. "It's a bunch of bullshit that a bunch of people two thousand years ago decided was what they wanted to hold over other people's heads. It's fucked up the world, it's fucked up *me,* and you want to be a part of that!?"

"No," Adora said. "I want nothing like that."

"Then why!?" Catra said. "They hate us! You think that's going to change!?"

Adora ran her hand over her Bible before sliding out onto her knees in front of Catra.

“You don’t think I know that?” she whispered as she took both of Catra’s hands in hers. The two knelt on the floor in front of each other, looking into the other’s tear soaked eyes. “You know what gives me strength to carry on?”

“It’s some verse, isn’t it?” Catra said in disgust.

Adora shook her head as she reached forward and gently touched the bottom of Catra’s lip before cupping her face as she said, “You.”

Catra took Adora’s hand away from her face as she said, “Stop it. Just… stop it.”

“I mean it, Catra,” Adora said.

“Then why don’t you just give that up!?” Catra said. “Why is it so important to you!?”

“Because I want to know,” Adora said.

Catra moved back a few feet as she said, “I don’t think… you and I…”

Adora felt her heart break as she sat back and said, “I don’t want…”

“You don’t want to be with me,” Catra said as she fought to keep the tears from falling and failing.

“No!” Adora said, her voice loud in the space as Catra jumped at the shout. “I have walked through fire for this! I may be damned to Hell for my love but that is the last thing I want!”

Catra’s tears fell harder as she said, “Do you… really?”

“Yes,” Adora said, scooting forward on her hands and knees until she was face to face with Catra again. “Remember what I said that night? Where you go, I will go. Where you stay, I will stay.”

Catra shook her head as she said, “But your God isn’t my God.”

“I don’t want it to be,” Adora said. “I’m not even sure what They look like anymore. That’s what I’m trying to find. I think of the hateful things that people say and then I think of the good I’ve seen as well. I think of the words, ‘but the greatest of these things is love’ and I can’t just turn away.”

Catra looked at Adora backlit by the light over the table, her blonde hair faintly glowing, and for a moment was back in a hot, tightly packed chapel one summer night not too long back as

Adora knelt over her and prayed that she loved Catra. Then she blinked and she was back in the moment.

"I don't want to leave," Catra said.

"I don't want to either," Adora said. "We can't go on like this though. I want to do this. I want to go to school for this. I want to go as far as I can but I want you there with me as I take the journey."

"I won't go on that journey with you," Catra said. "I don't want to study that."

"I don't want you to," Adora said. "I just want you by my side as I do."

Catra wasn't sure what to say but she could see Adora's face and she sighed before she responded.

"The first time you use the Bible against me in an argument, I'm gone," she whispered.

Adora nodded as she said, "I agree. I know how you feel, I promise I won't do that. I'll say it hurts when you insult my belief though. It feels like you're insulting me."

Catra nodded back as she said, “Alright, I’ll work on that, ok?” Adora nodded and Catra went on. “You know, I don’t understand why and I don’t think I ever will.”

“I don’t ask that you do,” Adora said. “Only that I get to love you.”

“I can do that,” Catra said. “I love you.”

“I love you too,” Adora said.

They looked at each other for a long drawn out heartbeat before they carefully kissed. They pulled back for a moment and then leaned in again for a longer kiss before Catra broke the kiss.

“What? What’s wrong?” Adora said, her heart beating fast as she began to worry.

“Nothing,” Catra said as she got up off the floor. “Well, I think we need to talk more but first, I have to show you something. Come here.”

Catra held her hand out and Adora took it as she began to lead her back to the bedroom.

“I’ve seen it before,” Adora said, trying to make a joke to break the tension.

Catra grinned back at her as she said, “Not that. Stay right there.”

Catra turned on the light in the bedroom before reaching under the bed. She came out with the cloth wrapped package she’d left there the day they’d arrived. She sat on the edge of the bed, Adora directly in front of her in the doorway, as she said, “I was going to give this to you at Christmas but I… I want you to have it now.”

“Catra, you don’t have to give me something,” Adora said.

“Think of it as a promise,” Catra said as she carefully unwrapped the cloth. Adora looked down to see an iron ring sitting in the middle of the cloth. It was thin, with a delicate twist, and it wrapped around itself on the top where a small iron feather sat.

“Did you make that?” Adora said, her eyes wide as Catra held it out to her.

“Finished it last week. I had to make an extra small chisel to cut the feather right,” Catra said as Adora took the ring and turned it in her hand, looking at it. “I think it’ll fit. I can adjust it if it doesn’t.”

Adora stared at the detail on the feather before she looked back at Catra and slipped it onto her left ring finger. It fit.

“Are you sure?” Adora said.

“About us?” Catra said, her face suddenly solemn. “No. I don’t know about this thing, like I said, I don’t think I’ll ever understand but I know I love you. I guess I have to have faith.”

Adora stepped forward and leaned down to kiss Catra.

“That’s all we can do,” she whispered.

Chapter End Notes

This story is going in a slightly different direction than I intended when I first started it way back in September. That's alright, I like where it's going. Thank you for reading!

# Chapter 9

Chapter Summary

A little later in the evening, Catra is still awake, wondering, and has to talk to Adora.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Later that evening, Catra lay in the crook of Adora's arm in the dark of the trailer, a thick blanket over the top of both of them. The gentle drip coming from the tap in the bathroom that they'd left going to keep the pipe from freezing seemed like a slow aquatic metronome for her thoughts.

"Adora?" she whispered.

"Mmmfff?"

"Sorry, go back to sleep."

"It's ok. You alright?"

"Yeah. It's just…"

Catra couldn’t think of what to say as she let the sentence hang as Adora shifted a little, her hand trailing along Catra’s back.

“Still thinking about earlier?”

“Always,” Catra said with a little snicker.

“Not that,” Adora said with a smile. “You know what I mean.”

“I do,” Catra said. “If we’re going to argue, let’s just do it in the morning though.”

“No, it’s alright,” Adora said. “You’ve got a question I’m guessing.”

“Yep, same one,” Catra said. “I just… I don’t get it. I guess people can believe all kinds of things and do whatever but you’re not people.”

“Gee, thanks,” Adora said and Catra poked her in the side.

“You know what I mean,” she said. “You’re part of my life. I guess I want to know.”

Adora said, “I guess… it’s just…”

She went silent as she tried to think of how to explain it better. Then she felt the ring on her finger and responded.

“Christmas.”

“Seriously?” Catra said, her tone flat.

“No, not like some cheesy movie,” Adora said, giving Catra a little hug. “I guess I’m trying to figure out how you go from a message like in Luke of peace on earth and good will to all to what we’ve seen.”

Catra didn’t respond at first but Adora waited it out.

“You know, I think you’re just being…,” Catra started to say and then stopped.

“Go ahead, say it,” Adora said.

“Naive,” Catra said. “I think it’s pretty obvious myself.”

It was Adora's turn to go quiet and Catra sat up in the bed, grabbing another blanket to throw around her shoulders in the cool air of the trailer, as she turned to look at Adora.

"I'm not trying to be an ass," she said softly.

Adora rolled over a little to look at her as she said, "I know. You might even be right. I still gotta know."

Catra nudged Adora with her foot as she said, "What do you think you're going to do? You going to figure out all the wrongs of religion and nail a decree to a church door somewhere?"

The comment drew a little laughing snort from Adora as she replied, "I mean, that did create a pretty big change to things."

"OK, new rule for the relationship," Catra said. "You can't start a Reformation of any kind."

"Please? If I'm really good and eat all my vegetables?" Adora said with a little whine in her voice.

Catra pushed her as she laughed and said, "I am not your mother, don't talk like that." Adora got quiet as Catra laid back down next to her. "You alright?"

“Yeah, sorry,” Adora said. “Just…”

“Your mother,” Catra replied.

“Yeah.”

“You regret it?”

“You? No. And the further away I get and the more I see, the more I realize just how messed up it was but…”

“What?” Catra said, taking Adora’s hand and kissing it.

“I still miss her,” Adora said so quietly it was almost inaudible.

“I get it,” Catra said.

“Do you really?” Adora asked.

“No, not really,” Catra said, “but I kind of do. It’s what you’ve known, right?”

"I guess that's part of it," Adora said. "It wasn't all bad. In fact… no, never mind."

Catra snuggled up close and kissed Adora before saying, "No, you started to say it, you have to finish it."

"I have this memory that's been on my mind. Around Christmas, we'd get dressed up and go to the church on a Saturday night. It'd be dark in the sanctuary except for all these candles. We'd go down to the front and sit in the front pew in front of one of the pastors. Other people would be in there doing the same with other pastors but not a lot, you know, just little groups like ours," Adora said as she looked past Catra in the dark and imagined the scene in her mind. "The pastor would greet us and we'd have a little prayer. He'd read a little bit of the Christmas story and then he'd serve us communion. The little crackers and juice, the words of the ceremony, there was always something about that to me, a little community moment of sharing and affirming what we had. Then we'd have another prayer and we'd go to the fellowship hall and Mom would go and talk with the adults and I'd talk with the other kids that were there and then we'd go home. I loved that experience. Mom was always so happy on those nights, I never understood why but I didn't question it."

Catra reached up and wiped the tears that were flowing from Adora's eyes.

"Why would I question it?" Adora said, her voice cracking. "I did everything she wanted. I was her perfect daughter and now she won't have anything to do with me because I fell in love. That's it, fell in love. Why is that so bad?"

Adora was shaking as the tears fell down her face. Catra pulled her in close, wanting to say so many things but not sure which one to even start with, as she stroked the back of Adora's head.

"Am I that bad?" Adora whispered.

Catra pulled away just enough to look into Adora's face and touched their foreheads together as she said low and fervent, "No. I think I don't understand you in a lot of ways but you are not bad. Do you hear me?" Adora nodded and Catra spoke again. "No, I want to hear. Do you hear me?"

"Yes," Adora whispered.

Catra kissed her before going back to putting their foreheads together.

"I love you, Adora Weaver," Catra whispered. "You are not a bad person and I will fight you if you say otherwise."

Adora gave a little choked laugh as she said, "I love you too, Catra Manzana."

They cuddled up together and soon Adora fell asleep. Catra watched her sleep until she was sure she was deeply asleep

before getting out of bed to get dressed. She looked down at Adora in the little bit of moonlight coming in through the curtains on the window before quietly leaving the trailer.

Adora woke up to whispered voices and sat up a little to see the flicker of candlelight coming from the little table. She could see Catra, Glimmer, and Bow standing right inside the door of the trailer and she realized it was their whispering that had woken her. She pulled the covers up around her as she sat up.

"Ummm, what's going on?"

All three of them looked back at Adora, a dim shadow in the back, and she almost laughed at the looks on their faces. They looked like they'd been caught doing something and then she noticed that Glimmer had a bottle of something in her hand and Bow was holding a cloth sack with something in it.

Catra took a few steps back to get to the room and said, "Sorry, I was hoping to have this setup before you woke up."

"What?" Adora said and then whispered. "Give me my sleep shorts and top."

Catra blushed a little but picked them up and tossed them to her before shutting the door. Adora got dressed and then pulled the blanket around her again against the cold air in the trailer since the heater was set low. She could hear a little bit of shuffling and

some noises that sounded mechanical from the front of the trailer and came out to find that Glimmer and Bow had collapsed the table into a small bed that the three of them were sitting on. The candlelight she'd seen was coming from a few small tin candle lanterns that were arranged around the space, the pierced tin backs throwing spots of light all over the walls.

"OK, it's the middle of the night," Adora said as she sat on the edge of a bench across from them. "What is going on?"

Glimmer looked at Catra as she said, "You didn't tell her?"

"I told you she was asleep," Catra said. "I was going to surprise her."

"Catra, what's going on?" Adora said as she rubbed her eyes.

Catra was taken for a moment by how cute Adora looked wrapped in a blanket and sleepy and didn't respond until Glimmer nudged her with her foot.

"Um, sorry, yeah, so I remember you saying earlier how you loved those nights of communion and I thought…," Catra said and trailed off as she took the bottle from Glimmer and the sack from Bow. She sat the sack down on the ground and leaned down to pull out a round bread loaf.

Adora took the bottle from Catra and looked at the label. It was a white label with neat handwriting that said it was mulberry wine with a bottling date a few months back.

"Did you… did you get them up to do communion?" Adora said as she looked up in surprise at Catra.

"I mean, yeah, kind of," Catra said, feeling awkward all of a sudden.

"She said you were feeling kind of homesick and thought we could do something like it," Bow said. Catra was giving him a look and Bow shrugged. "What? You did."

Adora reached over and took the loaf of bread from Catra and looked at the two in her hand as she said, "I don't know how I feel about this."

"I thought, as part of your little journey, we could maybe make it a thing, a part of you kind of thing," Catra said. "OK, I'm not making sense."

Glimmer jumped in and said, "Hey, or if you just want to hang out a little, we can do that as well."

Adora gave a little grin as she said, "No, it's alright, I think I know what you're going for." Then the smile slipped away as she looked

at the bottle. “Is this real wine? Cause we’re underage, I don’t want to get in trouble.”

“Yes, that is very real, and very good, wine and yeah, Mom wouldn’t like it very much but let's just not say and not make a habit of raiding their booze,” Glimmer said.

Adora looked down again for a moment and Catra could see a little conversation going on in her head that ended when Adora said, “Someone get me a cup please.”

Bow reached up into the cabinet and pulled down a plastic cup with the faded logo of a local marina on it as Adora fiddled with the wire and porcelain lid on the bottle to get it open. Bow held the cup out as Adora poured out about a half cup full before sitting the bottle on the ground at her feet. Bow set the cup on the shelf above him as Adora held the bread, not sure what to say. Then she suddenly looked up as she felt the bread moving and saw Catra with her hand on the other side, carefully taking it from her.

“Let me,” Catra said softly.

Adora nodded and let go. Catra tore off four roughly even pieces and handed a piece to each person as she began to speak.

“So I know the original that’s supposed to go with this but I don’t want to say that,” Catra said. “Communion means being together

and sharing. I… I'm not real good at that but when I'm with you all… I want to be because you're the first true friends I think I've ever had." Catra stopped and Glimmer put a hand on her shoulder and gave it a squeeze. Catra gave an embarrassed grin before she held up her little bit of bread. "I guess eat of this bread and remember that we're friends."

Adora put the bread in her mouth and began to chew. She remembered the communion wafers she'd had in the past, flat and dry tiny pieces of cracker like bread with no real weight or flavor, but this bread was dense and full of flavor that flooded her mouth as she felt tears in her eyes. Catra reached out with one hand to hold Adora's hand and with the other ate her piece of bread. There was silence as they all chewed and then Catra reached out with her free hand towards Bow, who took the hint and gave her the cup of wine.

"OK, so, the bread thing is all about being together and being part of one whole, part of a body I guess, but this is all about blood and being linked like a family," Catra said as she looked down into the cup as her voice cracked for a moment. "So, ummm, drink this and I'll be a part of all of you and you'll be a part of me, linked together."

Catra was looking around at everyone but as she said linked together, she was only looking at Adora as she held the cup up. Adora let go of Catra's hand to take it and Catra gave a little smile and shook her head as she carefully pushed Adora's hand aside. She held the cup to Adora's lips and Adora understood as Catra carefully gave her a sip of the wine.

Adora wasn't sure what she was expecting. She'd never drank alcohol before and the first flavor she tasted was a strong sweet flavor like a handful of bursting summer berries flooding her mouth. She felt the vapors go up her nose at the same time she tasted the bite of the alcohol hitting her tongue, all of it mixing with the sweetness, making it sharp and complex. She looked into Catra's eyes, each eye a different colored dark pool with the reflection of a flickering candle in them, as she swallowed the wine and as she did, she felt the feeling of being lifted up, of belonging, that she hadn't felt in so long and tears began to streak down her face because the feeling was like the wine, sweet and sharp and complex and she didn't know if she could speak at that moment even if she'd wanted to as she took the cup from Catra.

Adora held the cup in her hands and held it to Catra's mouth and gently tipped it forward. Catra took a sip and Adora was transfixed as she watched Catra slowly swallow it, her throat working as the liquid slipped down. Without taking her eyes off Catra, she held the cup out to Glimmer, who took it with a grin at her two friends staring at each other as if nothing else existed in the world. She turned to Bow and let him drink and he did the same before putting the cup back up on the shelf.

After a long moment of silence, Bow cleared his throat and Catra and Adora jumped a little.

"Umm… sorry," Adora said and Bow laughed.

"It's alright," he said. "That was beautiful. Thanks for getting us, Catra."

Catra gave a shy grin as she said, “Hey, it’s not a big deal.”

“Yes, it is,” Glimmer said as she put an arm around Catra and gave her a hug. “First real friends, remember? And if you don’t, I’m going to remind you. Constantly.”

Catra laughed and pushed her as she said, “I see, I’m vulnerable and this is how you treat me.”

Adora leaned forward and put her hand on the side of Catra’s face as she said, “I can’t believe you did this. Thank you. I love you.”

Catra’s eyes melted as she looked at Adora.

“I guess I do understand what you’re trying to do. Kind of,” she replied. “And I love you too.”

Chapter End Notes

> Catra has a last name! So, I needed a last name for Catra and I thought, "I'll be clever and translate applesauce into another language."
>
> If you don't know, that was the name that ND Stevenson said was Catra's last name in interviews he did after the show was over. I want to say he said that Catra and Adora gave themselves full names when they were little kids. Catra's full name was Catra Applesauce MeowMeow. I think Adora's was Adora Sparklefist but I can't remember that for sure. It was

all pretty tongue-in-cheek but the fandom, including myself, have run with it in one way or another.

Anyway, well, duh, applesauce is a compound word in other languages (at least according to online translators). Examples are compota de manzana in Spanish (and google translate was worthless, gave a completely different word) and compote de pommes in French. I figured I'd mash together the French version.

Yeah, Catra Compotepommes just sounds weird. So I ended up with Catra Manzana (technically Catrina Manzana since Catrina is her birth name here). It at least maintains the apple motif.

As to the communion scene, I was originally planning on doing just straight communion but as I was starting to write this chapter, I realized that Catra is not going to want to do that. It turned into what it was and this would have been posted two days ago if I didn't keep going over it and tweaking it over and over. I will say the one thing I almost put in at the last moment was when Adora took the cup from Catra, I was going to have her say, "I'll always take this cup from you." It's a reference to Jesus praying in the garden the day before his crucifixion and saying, "Father, if You are willing, take this cup from me." He's asking God not to send him to his death. In the end, I love the concept of Adora implying she'll shoulder the burden for Catra, she'll be there for her, but it felt tonally off to me for some reason and so it stayed out. The concept still works if you know the text because she's taking the cup from her though so I don't mind.

Anyway, thank you for reading!

# Chapter 10

Chapter Summary

> It's the night of the solstice and it's time for the ritual at the fire. Adora isn't sure how it's going to go but she knows that she's got something she wants to do.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The next few days were good. The four spent a lot of time together snugged up in Glimmer's room playing games or going for short walks. One day Glimmer got a boat out and they went out on the river, although neither Catra or Adora enjoyed that very much as the wind had a tendency to come right over the open water in a cold blast that seemed to drain heat faster than if they were on land. Finally, the solstice was upon them and Micah was full of energy as he ran around getting things loaded up into a little trailer that was attached to a UTV.

"I'm still a bit jealous we couldn't use that during camp," Catra said as she leaned against the porch railing.

"That's intentional," Micah said as he came back towards the house. "You can blame Sea Hawk."

"How deep underwater was it when you found it?" Catra said with a knowing grin.

“Reasonable assumption but nope, it wasn’t water,” Micah said. “He sank it in mud, which wouldn’t be so bad, but then he kept trying to get it out by himself and tore off several things and screwed up the drive system.”

“You keep him around why again?” Catra said as she followed Micah in.

“He’s a great guy!” Micah said. “Just don’t let him near anything that floats or drives without supervision.”

“Or that’s flammable from what I’ve heard,” Catra said and Micah gave a faked shudder.

“You have heard correctly,” he said with a grin as he grabbed a big bag. “Although he does make one hell of a campfire if I may say.”

“We talking about Sea Hawk?” Glimmer said as she came into the room.

“We are,” Micah said, “and his ability to light fires.”

“Oh, I remember one campfire he did,” Glimmer said. “It certainly was a fire.”

“Was that the one where it was taller than he was before he lit it?” Micah said.

“No, that wasn’t that bad, just hot,” Glimmer said. “I mean the one where he mixed brake fluid and some powder I can’t remember.”

Micah shook his head as he said, “Oh, yeah, that one. It wouldn’t have been so bad if everything hadn’t been soaked in kerosene.”

“You’re screwing with me, right?” Catra said.

“Nope,” Glimmer said. “Giant fireball. I have no idea how he didn’t lose more than just his eyebrows.”

“Because fire loves him dearly,” Micah said.

Catra laughed and grabbed the last bag and followed Micah out the door.

Adora, meanwhile, was sitting in the trailer next to one of Catra’s duffels that had clothes and a blanket crammed into it for the night as she wondered about the evening. She held a few pieces of folded paper in her hand, torn from her notebook with writing

filling them. She wanted to unfold it again and read it over but it wasn't for anyone's eyes and she'd said what had to be said.

Adora wasn't sure what she was about to see. She'd asked Glimmer and Glimmer had assured her it was just her dad doing a little ritual and then they'd hang around the fire all night, trying to stay awake if they could, and then there'd be another little ritual at sunrise before a hot breakfast at the house.

"The hardest part is staying up all night," Glimmer had said. "It's fourteen hours of darkness. Sun goes down a little after five and doesn't come up again until about 7:30 in the morning."

"And you just sit in the dark the whole time?" Adora had said.

"Well, in the dark around a fire and we're talking and laughing as well," Glimmer said. "Eating too. You want to do that, keeps you warm."

"This sounds like an ordeal," Catra had said from where she'd been stretched out on the floor.

"I mean, that's a bit of the point," Glimmer had said. "It's to remember the winter that is still to come and it's tied up in a death and rebirth thing but it's also to remember that you can make it through the hardship. Don't worry. I've been doing this since I was literally a baby. It's not about some macho who can survive the cold thing. If you're uncomfortable, say something."

Adora was uncomfortable now but she had to admit, it wasn't the cold or the wind that had her uncomfortable, it was the thought of the whole ritual. The anxiety she felt was from what she'd been told over and over was that she was about to do something evil but she couldn't help but think that wasn't the case. Either way, she was determined to see it through though and took a long breath before she grabbed the bag and headed out the door. Catra was sitting on the back porch waiting for her when she came out, the hood on her hoodie up. Adora felt her anxiety give way a little at the little molded cat ears that stuck up on it as she went over with a smile.

"We about ready?" Catra said.

"I guess," Adora said.

"Still got nerves about this whole thing?" Catra said as Adora set the duffel at her feet.

Adora looked out at the setting Sun as she gave a little shrug and scratched at her hand for a moment before saying, "Yeah, I kind of do."

"Well," Catra said as she got up and stretched before dropping an arm around Adora's shoulder, "I'll be sure to keep you close in case there's any…"

Catra trailed off and Adora looked at her.

"Any what?"

Catra shook her head as she said, "No, don't ask me to finish it. I was going to crack a joke you wouldn't have liked. Caught myself."

"Well how about you just hold me close in case of anything," Adora said with a little shy smile.

"I can do that," Catra said as she gave her a side hug.

They went around the front of the house to meet with the rest of the group and to wait for Micah to arrive and lead them to the fire ring. They saw they were the first ones there and in the quiet of the winter air, they could hear a car coming down the road towards the house. Adora took a quick look and saw that there weren't any missing cars.

"Were we expecting someone?" Catra said and Adora hid a grin at Catra including herself in the wider group.

"Not that I'm aware," Adora said as a little beat up pick up truck came out of the trees. It pulled up and parked beside Bow's van and a tall woman dressed in a heavy sweater with a canvas coat over it stepped out of the car. She wore a purple colored stocking

cap pulled low over her ears as she came around the truck and saw Catra and Adora looking at her.

“I’m sorry, is this not Camp Bright Moon?” she said.

“You’ve got the right place,” Adora said. “Who’re you looking for?”

The woman was about to answer when her head flicked to the side as the door to the house opened. Casta stepped out, as she tried to hide a huge smile, and calmly walked towards the woman.

“Well, Juliet, it seems you were able to make it after all,” Casta said as she stopped a bit over an arm’s length out of reach.

“Yes, it would seem I was able to do so,” Juliet said and took a step forward as Casta took a step back.

“Yes, it does seem that way,” Casta said as she dug the toe of her boot into the dirt for a moment.

“I can always go back to the house if you’d like,” Juliet said as she took a step forward again and Casta took a step back as if they were engaged in a very slow dance.

“I mean, if you want,” Casta said as she crossed her arms behind her back. “I don’t want to put you out or anything. I’ll be back in a few weeks at the latest.”

Juliet looked at her for a moment and then stepped forward. Casta took a step back again but this time Juliet took a big step and grabbed for her. Casta’s face changed from a hidden smile to wide eyed surprise as she started to fall backwards but Juliet had a hold of her and pulled her tight to her with a smile. They ended up leaning, Casta backwards and Juliet forward over her.

“If you think I’m going to wait a few weeks before I see you, I believe you have been drinking too much of your flask,” Juliet said, her voice low and throaty. Adora was already turning around and grabbing for Catra to do the same as Casta raised her head for a kiss.

“What was that for?” Catra said to Adora.

“We shouldn’t be staring,” Adora said, her face hot with embarrassment.

“Who was staring? That was amazing!” Catra said.

“Juliet! What are you doing to my aunt!?” they both heard Glimmer shouting with laughter from the porch.

“Just saying hello,” Juliet said as Adora risked a glance over her shoulder and saw Juliet pulling Casta back upright before holding her hand. Catra hadn’t waited and was already turned around.

“Well, Aunt Casta, I believe you need to introduce me to your girlfriend it would seem,” Glimmer said with a big grin as she walked forward, Bow coming out a bit behind her.

“You’ve met her,” Casta said.

“But not as your girlfriend. You know, your beau. Your swain. Your paramour. Your…,” Glimmer was saying before Juliet cut her off.

“Where in the world are those coming from?” she said.

“I am a college student,” Glimmer said, her voice refined and stuffy. Bow shook his head as he replied.

“She’s been reading a ton of romance novels,” he said. “It’s started leaking out.”

“Hey! Only because you got me into them!” Glimmer said.

“I’m not using paramour in a sentence though,” Bow said.

“Do you want me to say what you did say last night?” Glimmer said, a teasing grin on her face. Bow gave an embarrassed smile as he reached up to fiddle with the zipper on his coat.

“No, that’s alright,” he said.

“Could someone maybe introduce us over here?” Catra said and Glimmer nodded as she took charge.

“Juliet, or is it Aunt Juliet now?” Glimmer said and Juliet gave her a look. “OK, Juliet, these are my friends you’ve probably heard about. This is Adora and this is her girlfriend, Catra.”

Adora stepped forward with her best manners as she said, “It’s a pleasure to meet you, Juliet.”

“Hey, you managed not to ma’am her,” Catra said. Adora shot her a look as Juliet replied.

“Good to meet you two as well,” she said. “Looking forward to tonight?”

“I mean, I’m looking forward to not freezing,” Catra said as her eyes flicked up to the scudding clouds going past.

Juliet looked up as well as she said, “Hopefully it’ll stay cloudy but I doubt it.”

“Why would you want clouds?” Adora asked.

“If it’s clear, it’s colder,” Juliet said. “Nothing to trap the heat.”

A cold breeze slipped past them as Catra laughed and said, “Yeah, because there’s so much heat out here right now.”

“Every little bit matters,” Juliet replied.

“As you’ll find out tonight,” Glimmer said.

“You know, you say things like that and they wonder why Catra says it sounds like an ordeal,” Bow said as Angella came out of the house.

“Ah, Juliet, how unexpected,” Angella said with a smile. “And I see that the cat must be out of the bag now.”

“Well, they were canoodling when I saw them out the window,” Glimmer said.

“If everyone is going to make a deal out of this, well, I’ll have to take it since I’m not leaving but I’ll be irritated about it,” Casta said.

Angella had walked up to Juliet and Casta at that point as she said, “I’m just happy to see you happy again. Juliet, I wish you two the best.”

“Thank you,” Juliet replied. The group started chatting and a short while later, Micah came striding out of the woods.

“Juliet! Good to see you! Well, the Sun’s going down,” he said as he looked towards the sun and held his hand out in front of him to measure the distance to the horizon. “Got about an hour to go, it looks like. Everyone ready?”

There was a general agreement and Adora took a deep breath as she shouldered the bag she’d brought and followed the group as everyone followed Micah back into the trees. Micah and Angella walked together, hand in hand, through the trees. Glimmer and Bow were talking and laughing while Juliet and Casta hung back a little from the group, grinning at each other. Adora looked over at Catra, holding her hand, every few steps and marveled at the feel of Catra’s hand in hers.

The late afternoon light was cool and smooth and full of thin, shifting shadows as the light wind moved the little branches a little. Adora looked up as she heard a little rustling and saw a few

small brown birds fluffed up and tight together on a tree limb. She put her hand in her pocket and felt the folded up papers there, thinking about what it said on it as they walked into the campfire area. As they walked in, Adora noticed her shadow was cast straight ahead of her and fell over the campfire ring. She turned around to see the Sun low to the horizon, its light streaming through the opening where the path went through the bare trees that surrounded the campfire ring.

"Noticing how the Sun lines up?" Glimmer said as came to stand by Adora.

"Yeah, that's a pretty neat… wait, it's not a coincidence is it?" Adora replied.

"Nope," Glimmer said. "Dad worked to get the path to line up with the sunset on the winter solstice so it'd throw the final light on the fire ring." She pointed at another path on the other side of the campfire ring. "That one is lined up with the sunrise tomorrow. Bet you never noticed but there's a few places in camp that have things lined up with the summer solstice as well."

Adora couldn't help but smile a little at that. She saw the dedication to worship, as she'd think about it, in the effort Micah had put in. She turned as she heard someone coming up behind her and saw Micah smiling

"Few places that line up with the equinoxes as well," he said. "Just places that felt meaningful to me over the years so I commemorated them."

“Like what?” Catra said.

“You know that sign post that points the way to the barn that’s over by the south cabins?” Micah said. Catra nodded as he went on. “Ever notice the moon emblem on top has a moon shape cut into it with a piece of orange glass in the center? Right before sunset on the equinoxes, it throws that shape with the glowing orange center into the middle of the Sun that’s painted across from it on the cabin wall.”

“How did you work that out?” Catra said.

“Well, I could give you a bunch of mumbo-jumbo or I could just tell you that I have a compass and know how to figure out where celestial objects are going to be in the sky,” Micah replied.

“Ah, Dad, not even a little bit of mumbo-jumbo?” Glimmer said as she wrapped herself up in Bow’s arms.

“Alright, enough of that,” Micah said, trying to sound stern even while he was smiling. Then his eyes flicked towards the horizon and he looked around a little. “Well, let's make sure everything is where we want it now so we’re not stumbling around in the dark.”

He didn’t wait to see if anyone was going to say something and started bustling around the clearing, putting a few bags in a row by a big tent with one side raised towards the campfire ring itself and making an awning. Bow helped him out while Adora walked over to the fire setup. It consisted of an iron ring six inches high, covered in a fine layer of rust, and about two feet wide. Sitting in the middle of it, and filling it from one side to the other, was a big log that stood almost two feet above the ground. Stacked around one side of it were a few split pieces of wood and then smaller twigs from the width of a pinkie finger down to ones not much bigger than pencil leads. At the heart of it, sat a bundle of something fibrous. Adora looked at it as her hand slipped into her pocket and felt the papers again.

Glimmer had told her that it was a thing for them to burn things in the fire that they wanted to let go of in one way or another. Adora hadn’t been sure what she had wanted to let go of, and didn’t have very much either way, but she’d sat down one evening and wrote out a letter to her mother. She wrote how she missed her. She wrote how she was mad at her. She wrote about how she felt about how she’d been raised. She wrote about how she felt about Catra and how she didn’t think anything was wrong with what she was doing. She wrote to tell her about the plans she had for the future and what her hopes and dreams were. She wrote and wrote, filling many pages with anger, hope, love, grief, and faith before finally wrapping it up.

*Mother,* she had written, *in the end, I know you’ll never see this. Maybe that’s why it’s so easy to write out. I don’t think burning this is going to release anything for me but I want to try. One day, maybe, you and I will speak again and we’ll rebuild what was broken. I’d like that. I’d like you to meet Catra. She’s the greatest thing in my life and I hope you will meet and it’ll be good. I want to have faith that this will happen but I don’t think it will because this is more than a mountain and I don’t even have the faith of a*

*mustard seed. As you taught me, God wills these things to happen and it would seem that He has willed it that I would be hated by my mother for my love of another. We'll see.*

*Your Daughter,*

*Adora Weaver*

*I Corinthians 13:13*

"You seem really enthralled with that fire setup," Catra said as she came to stand beside Adora.

"Sorry, I was thinking about the whole consigning things to the fire thing," Adora said.

"Is this about whatever you've been furiously writing for the last day?" Catra said.

Adora nodded as she replied, "It's a letter to my mother."

Catra hugged her as she said, "I don't need to know."

Adora sighed as she said, "It's me rambling really."

“I hope it helps,” Catra said.

“Well, we’ll see,” Adora said as Bow and Glimmer came over.

“We’re about ready,” Glimmer said. “My favorite part is about to take place.”

“The lighting of the fire?” Bow said with a grin.

“The lighting of the fire!” Glimmer replied.

“Why is that the favorite?” Catra said and then turned as Angella replied from where she was sitting in a folding chair under the awning of the tent.

“Because Glimmer finds it funny watching Micah use a friction kit to light it.”

“It’s hysterical!” Glimmer said with glee.

“Hey, I’ll have you know that I have practiced more this year,” Micah said. “Got something a little different this year anyway.”

“I’ve still got the lighter ready for you,” Glimmer said as Micah reached into his pocket and took out a round wooden tube. “Wait, what is that?”

“Guess you’ll find out in a few,” Micah said with a little grin. “Alright, looks like we’ll have sundown pretty quick so shall we begin?”

There was a general murmur of assent as Angella, Juliet, and Casta got arranged around the fire and the others did the same until they were standing in a circle. Micah stood by the fire as he thought for a moment and then started talking.

“Tonight is the longest night of the year and we recognize the movement of our lives in this moment. The Sun slips away from us soon, not to be seen again for many long, dark hours,” Micah said as he turned and faced the sun that was almost touching the horizon now as Angella turned in almost perfect sync with him and the rest followed along a bit haphazardly. “I salute you and thank you for your gift of light, warmth, and life that you give to our world.”

He looked down at the fire as he said, “The Sun nourished and grew the cottonwood that gave us the gift of this log. I thank the cottonwood for its gift and promise that we’ll use it wisely as we reclaim a part of the light and warmth of the Sun from it tonight to see us through.”

Micah knelt down at the fire and looked at Glimmer who grinned back at him but didn’t say anything as everyone watched him. He

pulled the top of the round tube off and there was a little rod attached to it. He took a small bit of charred cloth out of his pocket and put it over the hole before carefully placing the rod on top of it and then slamming it down with his hand.

Everyone jumped a little as he pulled it back out and the little bit of cloth was stuck to the rod and glowing red. He carefully knocked it off into the bundle of tinder at the base of the fire before giving it a few puffs to get it going but pretty quickly the fire was crackling. He looked back at Glimmer who was still grinning but giving him a little thumbs up as she did.

He turned back to the sun, and everyone turned again as well to see the sun starting to sink out of sight.

"Farewell! Journey well and we look forward to your return!" Micah said as the Sun slipped out of sight. He turned out towards the woods as he went on, his voice getting quieter. "The long night has begun. It is not a time of despair for everything must have its end and that in this end is the seed of new life. Even now we move towards longer days, we move towards spring, and then summer, and then fall and soon we will be back here again. The wheel turns and we are turned with it as our lives mimic its movement and its seasons. Now is the time for introspection and of letting go. I ask each of you, do you have anything that you wish to let go of?"

Glimmer stepped forward as she said, "I do."

“Then consign it to the sacred fire, that it may be consumed and you shall walk free of it,” Micah said.

Glimmer stepped forward and deftly placed a picture into the fire. She had it face down so no one could see what it was and the fire, crackling high, took hold of it and it flared into flame and burned fast.

“Who else?” Micah said and Adora felt a shiver at his solemn voice. Juliet stepped forward as Micah gestured at the fire. She reached into her pocket and took out a ring. She held it in her hand for a moment before tossing it in. When she turned to Casta, she seemed to move lighter on her feet as Casta wiped at her eyes and grabbed her up in a hug.

“Who else?” Micah said and Adora stepped forward. Micah smiled at her and nodded. Adora took the letter from her pocket and looked at it for a moment as tears fought to spill over. She knelt down and felt the heat of the flames on her face and closed her eyes as she placed the letter down. When she opened her eyes it was already blazing with light and she stood up and stepped back beside Catra, who put her arms around her and hugged.

“Who else?” Micah said and no one else said anything or moved. He looked from person to person and said again, “Who else?”

Again, no one moved or spoke.

He spoke again as he said, “I asked a third and final time, who else?”

When no one moved, he began to raise his arms when suddenly Bow stepped forward. Micah looked at him as he lowered his arms and smiled as he gestured at the fire. Bow had a piece of paper folded into thirds. Adora tried to see what it was but only saw that it had some ornate blue border as he put it into the fire so deep that Adora was worried he was going to burn his hand for a moment. As he brought his hand back, he cupped it for a moment like he was gathering flame into it and then cast his hand up as if he was throwing it over himself. Glimmer stepped up behind him and wrapped him in her arms as Micah smiled.

Micah said, “May our vigil tonight be full of introspection and contemplation as well as love and togetherness as only together can we make it through the dark. Only together can we face the long nights of our lives. May the divine fire bless us all.”

He was silent and Adora wasn’t sure what to do as she surreptitiously looked around at the others. Everyone stood in silence for about a minute before Micah suddenly slapped his stomach and said in a regular voice, “Well, the long night is before us and I’m starving! Let’s get to eating!”

The next few hours were consumed with cooking over the fire, talking, laughing, and then, as it got late into the evening, settling down under the tent in the blankets and sleeping bags. Micah was the only one who didn’t, electing instead to sit on the ground beside the fire leaning back against a small tripod with a panel set against it. The cottonwood log made little crackles and snaps as it burned but gave off little light.

Catra lay on the ground covered in a blanket and sleeping bag as she watched the fire. Adora sat beside her, looking up into the moonless sky, and marveled at how crisp and sharp the stars looked. She'd heard people say the stars looked like jewels across the sky and she had to admit that it looked exactly like small jewels thrown across velvet.

"There's my old friend, Orion," Glimmer said suddenly. Her voice was quiet, barely a whisper, and Bow gave her a little hug as she spoke.

Adora looked around for a late comer to the party until she suddenly realized Glimmer was referring to the constellation.

"Where?" she asked, her voice equally quiet.

Glimmer pointed again as she said, "See those three bright stars in a line and then three more coming down from them?"

Adora looked and then said, "Yes."

"That's his belt and sword sheath," Glimmer said. She pointed to a few other stars as she went on. "There's his shoulders and you can just see his arm. He's got a dog too. It's the constellation that has that really bright star over there, Sirius."

Adora looked at the stars as she said, “I never really got to learn those.”

“Why not?” Bow asked.

“I can guess,” Catra said as she put a hand on Adora’s leg.

Adora covered the hand with her own as she said, “You’d be right.”

“Wait? Seriously? It’s a religious thing?” Bow asked.

Adora nodded as she said, “It leads to belief in astrology and fortune telling, which is of the Devil.”

“You’re messing with me, right?” Glimmer said.

“She is not,” Catra said. “Remember that cartoon about the mutated alligators living in the sewers?”

Bow said, “Oh yeah, Teenage Mutant Pirate Gators. I loved that.”

“Yeah, well I lived with a family for a while when I was a kid, they forbid us from watching it,” Catra said. “Said it was a tool of Satan to trick us into worshiping abominations. I thought it was cool. I learned not to watch it.”

The last sentence caused Catra to tense and reach up for a moment to her arm. Adora lay down beside her and pulled her into her arms as Catra rolled over to face her. Glimmer and Bow went quiet as they shuffled around on the ground a little.

“Wasn’t trying to bring it down,” Catra said.

“Well, you did,” Glimmer said with a barely visible smile in the dark as she reached over to nudge Catra. Catra looked over at her and gave a little snorting laugh.

“You dig into my childhood, you’re going to get the awkward,” Catra said.

“Honestly, it’s probably the same with me,” Adora said.

“I already knew that,” Glimmer said. “I’ve lived with you these last few months. You’ll say the most casual thing about your past that’s just a huge, ‘What the hell!?’ moment.”

Adora looked over at the fire as a little flame licked up off the log for a moment as she said, “Well, hopefully that’s behind me.”

“That’s what you burned, huh?” Glimmer said.

“Something like that,” Adora said.

“I burned an old picture of someone I thought was a friend,” Glimmer said.

“That one from high school?” Bow asked and Glimmer nodded as Bow looked over at the fire as well. “I burned a copy of my original birth certificate.”

All three sets of eyes were suddenly focused on Bow in the dark.

“I can feel you staring at me,” Bow said with a little laugh before he became wistful. “I think about who I was and I love her. Without her, I wouldn’t be me.”

“Then why sever the connection?” Catra asked.

“Because she deserves to rest,” Bow said. “She was scared and confused and didn’t understand what was going on but she was so brave and I hope she rests in peace.”

Glimmer hugged him tight and he hugged her back as Adora and Catra shuffled over to do the same.

"I hope she does too," Glimmer whispered. "I hope we all do."

They sat in silence for a while and eventually Bow bundled up and fell asleep. Catra left with Juliet and Casta to go visit one of the bathrooms that wasn't far off from the ring while Micah was still by the fire, not moving for long stretches of time. Angella joined him and was laying on the ground with her head on his leg as she looked into the fire and Micah quietly sang something to himself that Adora couldn't quite make out but that she'd find herself remembering for years to come.

Chapter End Notes

> If you're wondering what I Corinthians 13:13 is, it reads, "And now these three remain: faith, hope and love. But the greatest of these is love."
>
> Also, you may be saying, "What is that thing about mountains and mustard seeds that Adora is talking about in her letter?" That's a reference to something that Adora would have heard a lot growing up (I know I did). It's a reference to Matthew 17:20 that says, "So Jesus said to them, "Because of your unbelief; for assuredly, I say to you, if you have faith as a mustard seed, you will say to this mountain, 'Move from here to there,' and it will move; and nothing will be impossible for you." Basically, she's saying, "Listen, I want to have faith but this is bigger than a mountain and I don't even have the faith to do that."
>
> When I mentioned Teenage Mutant Pirate Gators, it took everything I had not to come up with an alternate version of She-Ra instead. I decided that was a bit too meta.

The part with Bow talking about how he hopes his past self rests in peace is taken from a single piece of art that ND Stevenson did in his memoir, The Fire Never Goes Out: A Memoir in Pictures. It’s a picture of him holding his younger self, who’s on fire, with the caption, “Love your younger self and let them die.” When I saw that, reading it right after it came out, I cried. The whole memoir is moving, and tear-jerking, but that one piece stuck with me so hard. That’s what I was trying to capture.

I think we're just about to end of this and it's been a ride. I did not expect this to end up being almost as long as the original story of the series (which I also didn't think was going to be that long). Anyway, thank you for reading and your comments! I've enjoyed them, even if I've occasionally been slow in replying.

# Chapter 11

Chapter Summary

Adora sits in the dark and thinks.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“How far off do you think sunrise is?” Adora said softly as she stretched. “Gotta be just a few hours.”

Glimmer gave a quiet laugh as she said, “Adora, it’s not even midnight yet.”

Adora looked at her in surprise as she said, “Seriously?”

“Yeah,” Glimmer said as she pointed at Orion. “Orion there will be due south at midnight. He’s still got a little ways to go before then. He’ll set in the west about two hours or so before sunrise.” Adora looked at the constellation for a moment before looking at Glimmer who shrugged as she went on. “I did say I’ve been doing this since I was literally a baby.”

“It feels way later,” Adora said as she pulled a blanket a little tighter around herself.

“Dad didn’t call it the long night for nothing,” Glimmer said. “It’s alright if you go to sleep you know.”

Adora shook her head as she said, “No. I want to try and stick it out.”

“Fair,” Glimmer said. “I sure won’t.”

An hour passed. Glimmer went to sleep curled up under some blankets with Bow. Catra had gone to sleep as well shortly after she’d got back with Juliet and Casta. Angella had come back to the tent as the temperature continued to drop and gone to sleep herself. Juliet hadn’t been long after that. Soon, it was just Casta and Micah around the campfire and Adora sitting in the tent, looking out into the darkness.

Adora had been thinking about the ceremony and while it was something she’d never experienced, she still felt like she could feel the similarity to the services she’d attended at her old church. It had felt like the lead up to the frenzied dancing and singing and speaking in tongues to her, the part where the pastor would lay out the message for the day. The difference now was the long, silent darkness where she was essentially alone with her thoughts, instead of able to escape thought in the frenzy of worship.

After a little bit of psyching herself up, she finally stood up and walked over to the fire. Casta and Micah both looked up at her as she stood a little ways back from them.

“Don’t hover there,” Casta said. “Sit down and get some warmth.”

“I am ok,” Adora said as she rethought getting up

“I know what you’re thinking and you’re not intruding,” Micah replied. “Have a seat.”

Adora didn’t wait and sat as she pulled off her mittens to hold her hands to the fire.

“Thank you,” Adora said.

“You holding up alright?” Micah asked.

“I am,” Adora said and then looked at Casta as she reached inside her skirt’s pocket for a moment. She came out with a piece of wrapped chocolate that she held out to Adora.

“What’s that for?” Adora asked as she took the chocolate.

“You didn’t call him sir or mister,” Casta said, her grin visible even in the dim light of the coals.

Adora shook her head but she was smiling as she unwrapped the chocolate.

"You going to keep the full vigil?" Micah asked.

"I'm going to try," Adora said.

"What do you think of it so far?" Micah asked.

Adora looked down into the fire, not sure how to respond. She didn't want to say it reminded her of church but she couldn't think of what else to say as Micah and Casta sat quietly waiting for her response. Adora picked up a small stick of wood and placed it on the coals and watched as it burst to flames. As it died down, she finally spoke.

"It's like… it reminded me of church in a way," Adora said. "I don't mean to offend but it did."

"No offense given or taken," Micah replied. "I guess I can see your point. Probably a valid one too, although I couldn't say for certain. I haven't been in a church since I married Angella and that was a while ago."

The conversation ended there and after a little while, Casta stood up and wished them good night

before going to the tent to sleep beside Juliet.

It was a night Adora would never forget. She remembered watching the stars move and seeing frost form. Her and Micah said little to each other as they both huddled in close to the fire but it was a comfortable silence and for all intents she was alone with her thoughts which were long and slow and seemed to turn on her as she'd approach them. Adora found herself gazing at the flickering coals that consumed the cottonwood log for undetermined stretches of time that felt long and instant all at once.

As Orion crept across the sky Adora would occasionally get up, walk around the clearing to look into the pitch-dark woods. She'd check on Catra, who was little more than a lump under blankets and sleeping bag like the rest, before going back to the fire. She seemed to just slip into the moment as time seemed to just happen. Everything was darkness, the cold, flickering coals, sleeping people, and Micah as a mostly silent figure in the dark with her. It was the first time in months that she felt truly at peace.

Then, she looked at the sky to realize she couldn't see Orion. It was then she noticed a faint glow and it took her a moment to recognize it for what it was.

"Is that the sunrise?" Adora whispered.

Micah nodded as he whispered back, "That's the sunrise. Sun won't be up for about another hour but that's the start of it. You

made it through. How do you feel?”

Adora had a lot of thoughts and feelings but she knew she’d have time to work them out later so she spoke what was most immediate among them.

“Hungry. Tired too.”

Micah’s smile was ear to ear as he nodded and said, “Same. We’ll start waking everyone up in a few so they can be up for the dawn.”

They were all gathered around the fire at dawn, the cottonwood log that had seemed so large at sundown the day before burned down to almost nothing. The ceremony was simple as Micah talked about what they had just gone through and then, as the Sun came over the horizon, welcomed it back with a resounding shout that caused everyone to jump a little. Adora pulled Catra close to her and closed her eyes as she felt the feeble warmth of the Sun washing over her face. They all returned to the house and the breakfast was large, as promised. Adora fell asleep on the couch in the living room to wake up mid-afternoon covered with a thick blanket as Catra sat at the foot of the couch playing cards with Bow and Glimmer.

The rest of the vacation was good. Casta had made everyone, including Catra and Adora, sweaters for Christmas. Adora felt guilty as she hadn’t been able to get anyone anything but after her fifth apology, Bow finally said, “Adora, let it go. You’re here, that’s what matters.”

The celebration of the new year was fun and energetic as friends of Micah, Angella, Casta, and Juliet all came to the house. Adora, Catra, Bow, and Glimmer eventually retreated to the trailer and were curled up under blankets in the tiny bedroom, laughing and talking when the new year rang in. There was a brief pause for each couple to have a kiss followed by questions of what was to come in the new year. Adora pulled Catra close as she said, "I don't care. As long as you all are there."

Chapter End Notes

I had started this awhile back and had intended to have it down by Christmas of 2022. That did not work out as you can tell. I don't like updating stories haphazardly. I prefer a pretty set schedule, such as once a week, otherwise I worry I won't get it done. This one was kind of starting to worry me because it just kind of got updated at weird intervals. I know in fandom that it's not unusual to have a story just not be finished but I always swore I wouldn't do that when I started writing fic and so far, I haven't. Hopefully I won't. It's also part of the reason I end series instead of just letting them stay open. I want to be able to end them so there IS an ending, so that I don't keep trying and make bad stories just to keep it going, but also so people don't see an open series and think there will be more coming.

All of that is to say, I am looking at ending this series. I don't think it'll be soon, I still have some stories I want to tell in this AU, but I have already started writing the very last fic for it. This series, out of all of my series, is the one that has absolutely touched me the deepest. My post-season five series is a lot of fun. I love writing it and I've got some great compliments such as one person who said they considered it canon for after the show. My Shadow Weaver lives series was interesting to write and my Catradora break up series was a big departure from my normal writing and such. However, this series has been incredibly personal for me and I know it

has been for many people, especially the first story in the series. The comments I've gotten have moved me to tears in some cases and I can't even begin to say how much it means to me that people have found so much that is important to them in something I did. That's why I want to end it. I want it to continue to be something that is important to people and not something that just kind of limps along.

I'm not done writing fic. I've got several open series I need to wrap up at least and I know I've got more She-Ra stuff I could do besides that. As to this though, thank you so much to everyone who's read this. I write for myself but I share it for everyone. May love continue to shine and save the universe.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!